EXPLORASELF

WORTH BUILDING

The Founder's Playbook

32 Leadership Frameworks

to Turn Grit into Growth
and Build a Business That Lasts

ALEXANDRU COJOCARI

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THE FOUNDER'S MANUAL

32 frameworks to lead yourself, your people, your business and your market

ALEXANDRU COJOCARI

SELF	PEOPLE	WORK	MARKET
Lead yourself	Lead people	Lead the business	Lead in the market

MY PROMISE TO YOU

YOU WILL NOT FINISH THE SAME

This manual will not make your decisions for you. No book can. What it will do is put the right question in front of you, at the right time, on one clear page.

Spend one honest hour with it each week. Within a season you will know what you want, who you need beside you, what your business really runs on and who you are built to serve.

Every tool here is one I use with founders and business owners. Use what works. Leave the rest for the season you need it. Do the work, and you will not finish this manual as the same person who opened it. That is my promise.

Alexandru

HOW TO READ THE PAGES

- Empty square or box: write here
- **1** Numbered square: how to use the drawing
- Bronze: your priority, the one that matters most
- Navy band: the domain you are in

ABOUT THE EXAMPLES

The worked examples are realistic composites written to show each framework in use. Names, places and figures are illustrative, not real clients.

CREDITS

ExploraSelf frameworks are original to the author. Classic frameworks are credited on their own pages to the people who created them, and appear here rewritten in ExploraSelf form. Scripture quotations are from the King James Version. Quotations from Seneca are from the translation by Richard M. Gummere, from Marcus Aurelius from the translation by George Long, and from Sun Tzu from the translation by Lionel Giles.

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WHY THIS MANUAL

PRINCIPLES THAT NEVER GET OLD

Tools change every year. Today a machine can write your emails, analyse your numbers and draft your strategy. It cannot decide for you who you want to be, what you can carry, where you go and how big you are willing to grow. That is leadership, and it has never been worth more.

This manual holds 32 frameworks I use with founders and business owners. Some are mine; some are classics I have tested and rewritten. Each fits on two pages: the tool on the left, and on the right how to use it, a worked example and a few thoughts that will still be true in fifty years.

Do not read it like a novel. Use it like a toolbox. Open the page your week needs, work with a pen, and come back in 90 days.

ONE THING TO DO THIS WEEK

Read the contents and circle the three frameworks your business needs most right now.

Alexandru

ALEXANDRU COJOCARI · ROME

PHOTO 01

Portrait, at least 1,300 × 2,800 px

Natural light or black and white

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HOW THIS MANUAL WORKS

Four domains, three layers of wisdom and four rules to hold before you pick up any tool.

FOUR DOMAINS

SELF PERSONAL INTERNAL *Who am I, and who am I becoming?*	**PEOPLE** PERSONAL EXTERNAL *Who am I for others, and who are they to me?*
WORK BUSINESS INTERNAL *What do I truly care about, and does it pay?*	**MARKET** BUSINESS EXTERNAL *What does the world want and need from me?*

PERSONAL BUSINESS

THREE LAYERS ON EVERY SPREAD

PRINCIPLE · WHY
The bold line at the top of each framework. The law that does not change.

STRATEGY · WHAT
The drawing and the five moves: the method you can repeat.

TACTICS · HOW
The worked example, the questions and your quick note: what you do this week.

HOW TO USE IT

ONE FRAMEWORK A WEEK
Pick the page your week needs. Work with a pen, on the page or on a separate sheet.

DECIDE WITH P.A.C.E.
Pause, assess, choose, execute. Every framework ends in a decision and a date.

RETURN EVERY 90 DAYS
Your answers will change, because you will.

FOUR RULES BEFORE THE TOOL

1	2	3	4
IDENTITY RULES EVERYTHING You will act like the person you believe you are. Start there.	**MASTERY IS THE WAY, NOT THE END** There is no final level. There is only the next honest step.	**THE OASIS IS COMING** Every desert season ends for those who keep walking.	**WHAT YOU NEED TO START IS ALREADY IN YOU** Tools help. Decisions, courage and character are yours.

PHOTO 02
Portrait, at least 1,300 × 2,800 px
Natural light or black and white

ON LEADING YOURSELF

THE FIRST BUSINESS YOU RUN IS YOU

In my late teens I built kitchens and wardrobes to measure. I loved the work and the clients. I did not manage the money, the orders ran late, and my father closed the business. The lesson took three years: the business was never stronger than the person running it.

Years later, in 2019, I won in Classic Physique at an IFBB competition. Nobody can lift the weights for you, eat for you or sleep for you. Business is the same. Your team can do many things. Leading you is not one of them.

This part is about the founder's inner operating system: goals, decisions, identity, focus and discipline. Start here, even if you are tempted to skip to sales.

ONE THING TO DO THIS WEEK
Score yourself on the Five Forces before you read any further.

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01



SELF

LEAD YOURSELF

Who am I, and who am I becoming?

Your goals, decisions, identity, energy and discipline: the founder's inner operating system.

01 The 10-5-3-1 Goal Ladder 8

02 The P.A.C.E. Decision Loop 10

03 Be, Do, Have, Become 12

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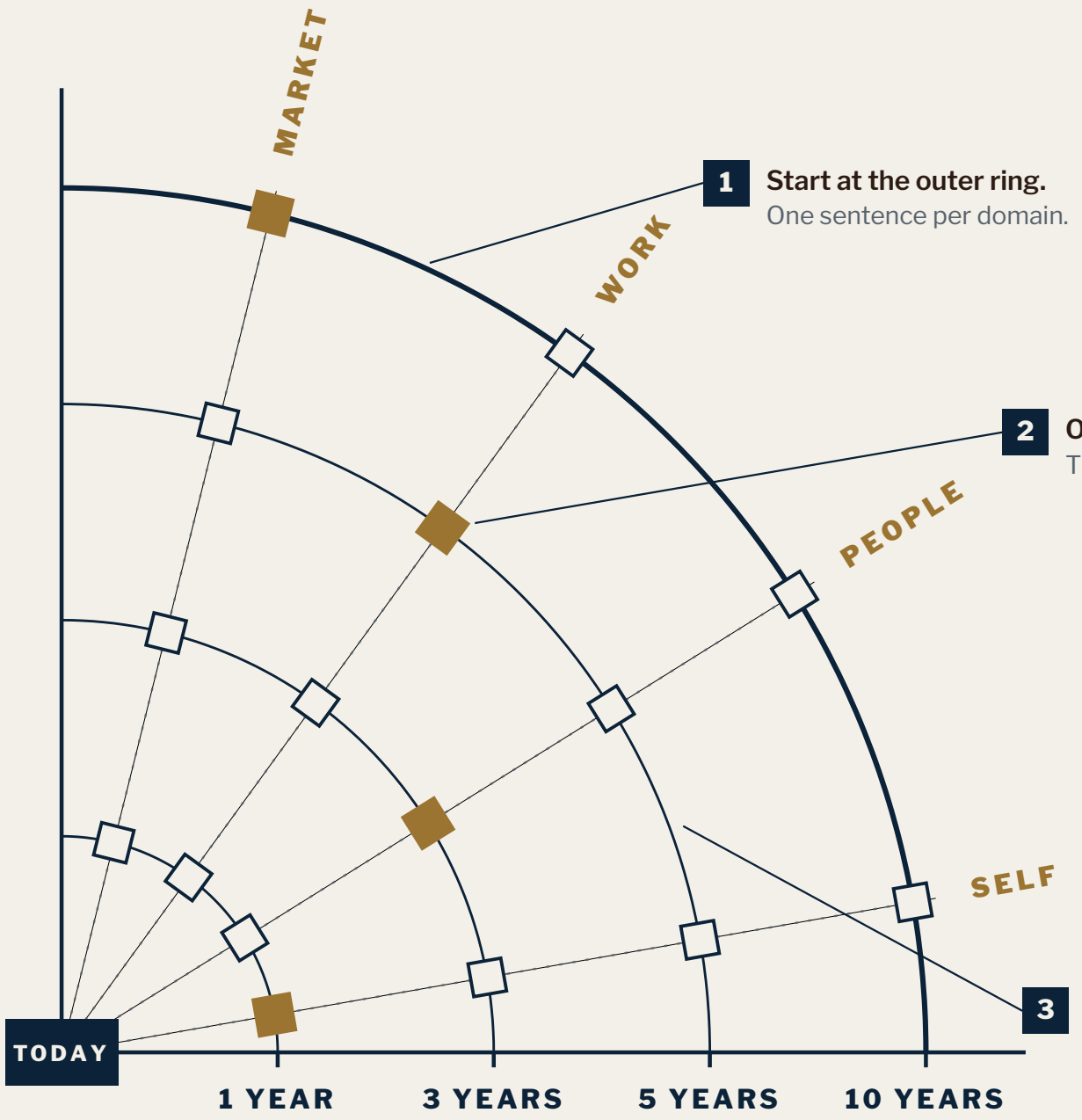
07 The CEO's Four Boxes 22

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THE 10-5-3-1 GOAL LADDER

> *See the summit before you choose the next step. Decide where you are going in ten years, then walk back to what this year must prove.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL



1 **Start at the outer ring.**
One sentence per domain.

2 **One solid square per ring.**
The priority for that horizon.

3 **Walk inward, ring by ring.**
Each makes the next likely.

☐ Empty square: one goal, one domain, one horizon ■ Solid square: the one priority on that horizon

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

45 minutes once a year · review every 90 days · work on a separate sheet or in your journal

1. **Start at ten years.** For each domain, write one sentence that would make you proud. Let the dreamer speak; don't edit yet.
2. **Walk back to five, three and one.** Each horizon must make the next one likely. If a step feels too big, the ring below is missing something.
3. **Choose one priority per horizon.** Which goal, once reached, makes the others easier? Fill that square. Everything else supports it.
4. **Invite the critic.** What could stop this? What will you stop doing this year to make room?
5. **Turn year one into this quarter.** One result, one weekly habit, one date in your calendar. Review with P.A.C.E. every 90 days.

WORKED EXAMPLE — Luca, 41 · accounting firm in Milan · 9 people

10 YEARS	■ MARKET	The firm family businesses in Lombardy trust first. He teaches young founders one evening a month.
5 YEARS	■ WORK	Two offices, 25 people. The firm runs a full month without him.
3 YEARS	■ PEOPLE	Two partners who lead client work and hire without asking him.
1 YEAR	■ SELF	He stops doing the books himself and protects two mornings a week for strategy.

WHAT HE STOPPED
Taking every small client himself.

THIS QUARTER
Hire one senior accountant by 31 March.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

If nothing changes, where will I be in ten years, and can I accept that?

Which goal am I choosing because it impresses others?

Who do I need to become to reach each solid square?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
A goal is a decision about who you will become. The result is the proof, not the point.

LEADERSHIP
People follow a leader who can say where we are going and why. Clarity is a form of kindness.

BUSINESS
Most founders overrate one year and underrate ten. Compounding is patient, and it rewards the focused.

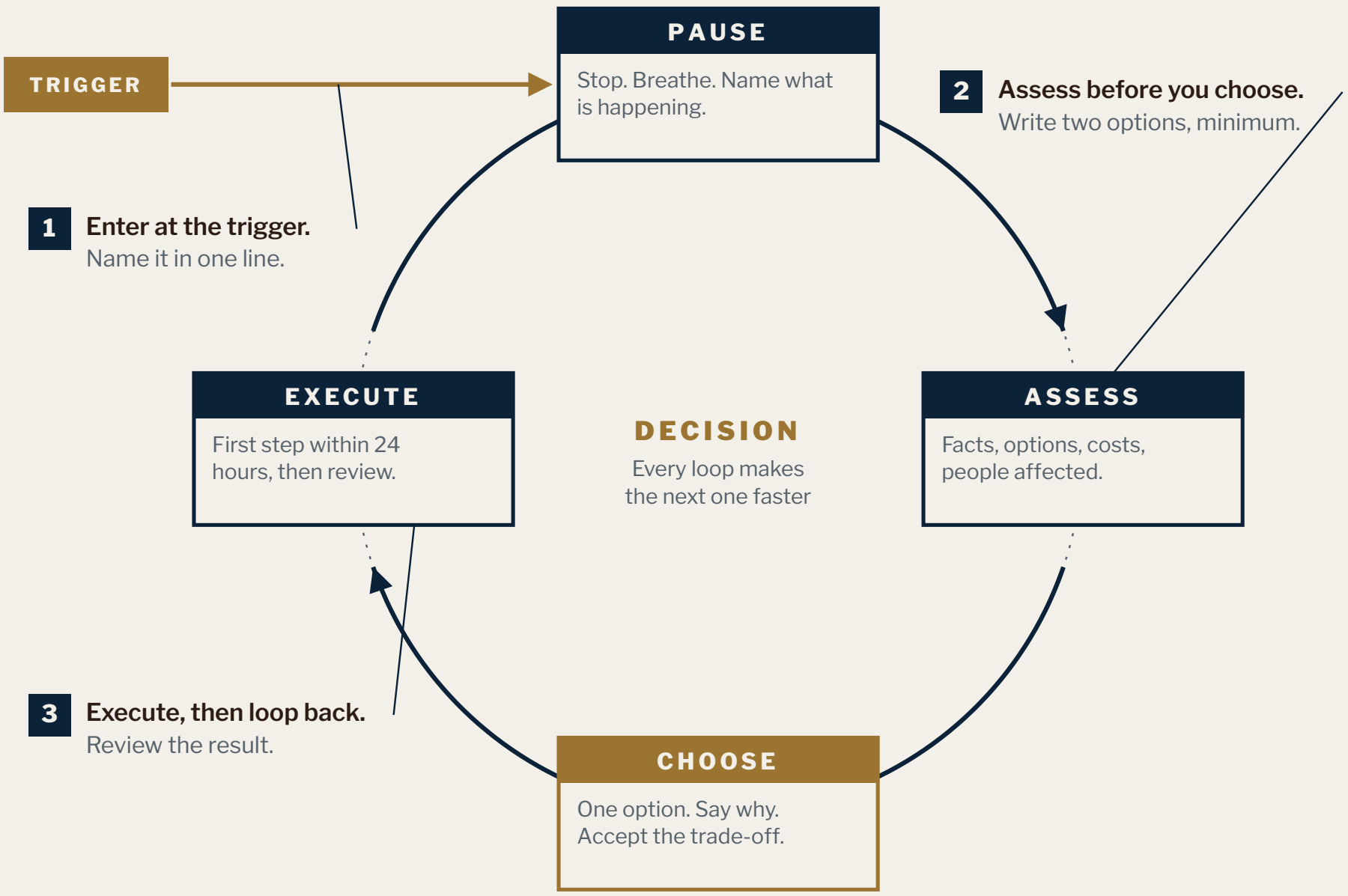
PERSONAL
Write your ten-year goal for your family and health first. Wealth that costs them is a loss.

> *"When a man does not know what harbour he is making for, no wind is the right wind."*
> SENECA, LETTERS TO LUCILIUS

THE P.A.C.E. DECISION LOOP

> *Between what happens and what you do there is a gap. Leaders widen it. Pause, assess, choose and execute, and stop reacting your way through the week.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL



☐ Write your notes inside each stage ■ Gold stage: the moment you commit

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

5 minutes for small decisions · one night for big ones · use it before any reply you might regret

1. **Catch the trigger.** Notice the moment you want to react: an email, a loss, a complaint. Write it in one line.
2. **Pause on purpose.** Ten breaths or ten minutes. Big decisions get a night. Speed is a choice, not a reflex.
3. **Assess the real situation.** Facts first, then at least two options, then the cost of each, then who it affects.
4. **Choose and own it.** Pick one option, say why in one sentence, and accept what you give up.
5. **Execute and review.** Take the first step within 24 hours. Put a review date in your calendar and learn from the result.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Sofia, 36 · online skincare shop in Lisbon · 4 people
TRIGGER	Her main supplier raises prices by 18% with two weeks' notice.
PAUSE	She waits until morning instead of sending an angry reply.
ASSESS	Absorb the cost, raise prices by 6%, or find a second supplier. She runs the numbers on each.
CHOOSE	Raise prices by 6% now and test a second supplier within 60 days.

WHAT SHE GAVE UP	REVIEW DATE
A few price-sensitive customers.	Margin check on 1 June.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which decision am I making too fast right now?
What would I choose if I were advising a friend?
What am I willing to give up for this choice?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Freedom lives in the pause. Whoever controls your reaction controls your business.

LEADERSHIP
Teams copy the leader's pace under pressure. A calm decision spreads faster than a panicked one.

BUSINESS
Most costly decisions are not wrong; they are rushed. A night's sleep is the cheapest consultant you will ever hire.

PERSONAL
When you are tired, hungry or angry, decide only what cannot wait.

> *"Let every man be swift to hear, slow to speak, slow to wrath."*
> JAMES 1:19

BE, DO, HAVE, BECOME

> *Most people chase the have. Leaders start with the be. Decide who you are, act like it every day, and the results follow. Who you become is the real return.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL, FROM THE HOUSE OF WISDOM

BE

IDENTITY

Who am I as a leader? Write it as: I am a founder who...

DO

ACTIONS

What does that person do every week? Three actions you can tick.

HAVE

RESULTS

What will those actions create within a year? Be specific.

BECOME

Results reshape who you are, and the loop starts again

1 **Start with BE, not HAVE.**
Write it in the present tense.

2 **Close the loop every quarter.**
Who are these habits building?

☐ Write in each box, from left to right ■ Gold loop: who you are becoming

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

30 minutes to write · read it every Monday · rewrite it once a quarter

1. **Write the BE.** One sentence in the present tense: I am a founder who keeps promises and decides with facts.
2. **List the DO.** Three actions that person takes every week, written so you can tick them off.
3. **Name the HAVE.** The results you expect within a year if you keep the DO. Revenue, clients, health: be specific.
4. **Check the order.** If you wait to have before you do, or to do before you are, you stall. Start at the left.
5. **Review who you become.** Every quarter ask: what kind of person are these habits building? Adjust the BE if needed.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Andrei, 33 · construction firm in Bucharest · 14 people
BE	I am a builder whose word is worth more than a contract.
DO	Calls every client on Friday. Never promises a date he has not checked with the site.
HAVE	Repeat clients, referrals, fewer disputes and 20% more margin within a year.
BECOME	A man his crews trust and his clients recommend.

WHAT CHANGED FIRST	THIS QUARTER
His calendar, not his bank balance.	Friday calls, 12 weeks in a row.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which result am I chasing while ignoring the identity behind it?

What would the person I want to be do this week?

Who am I becoming with my current habits?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Identity rules everything. You will not keep a habit that contradicts who you believe you are.

LEADERSHIP
People follow who you are long before they follow what you say.

BUSINESS
Revenue is a lagging indicator of character and habits. Work on the leading ones.

PERSONAL
Do not wait to feel like a leader. Act like one and the feeling catches up.

> *"No longer talk at all about the kind of man that a good man ought to be, but be such."*
> MARCUS AURELIUS, MEDITATIONS

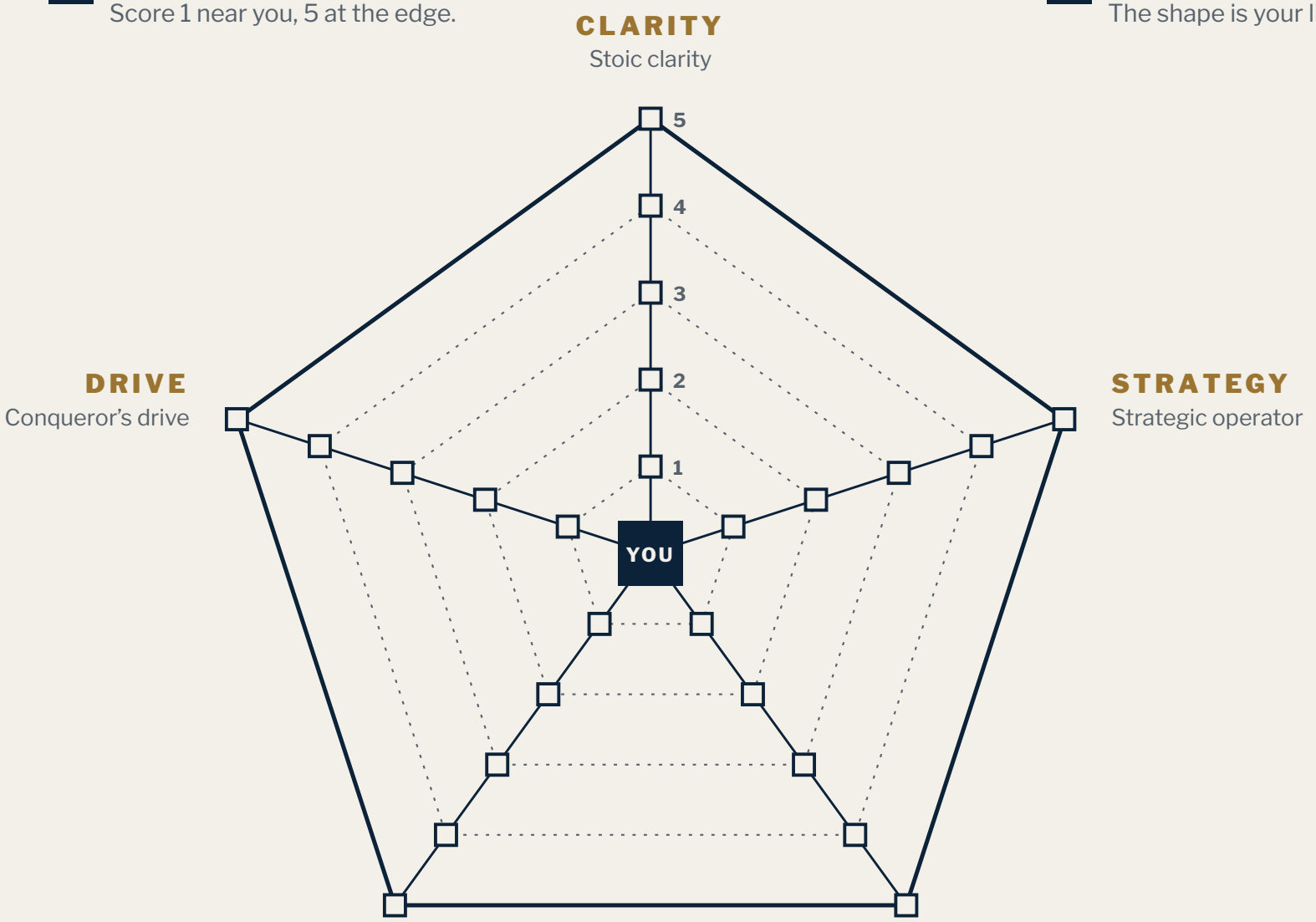
THE FIVE FORCES

> *Your business cannot grow beyond the person leading it. Five forces set your lid. Find the lowest and raise it before you ask for more.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL, FROM ALLOW YOURSELF TO RISE · BUILDS ON JOHN C. MAXWELL'S LAW OF THE LID

1 **Fill one square per line.**
Score 1 near you, 5 at the edge.

2 **Join the five dots.**
The shape is your lid.



3 **Raise the lowest point,**
not the highest.

□ Squares: scores from 1 (centre) to 5 (edge) ■ Your lid: the lowest force

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

20 minutes · score the last 90 days, not your best day · re-score every quarter in a new colour

1. **Score honestly.** Rate each force from 1 to 5 based on the last 90 days. Ask someone close to score you too.
2. **Draw your shape.** Join the five points. Dents show where your leadership leaks.
3. **Find the lid.** Your lowest score caps everything else. That is the force to train first.
4. **Train one move.** Pick one weekly practice for that force and keep it for 30 days.
5. **Re-score every 90 days.** Use a different colour each time. Growth becomes visible.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Elena, 44 · dental clinic in Rome · 11 people
SCORES	Clarity 4, strategy 2, command 3, discipline 4, drive 5.
THE LID	■ STRATEGY Busy every day, but no plan beyond next month.
ONE MOVE	A two-hour strategy block every Friday, phone off, for 30 days.
90 DAYS LATER	Strategy 4. She opened Saturday hours and launched hygiene plans.

WHAT SHE STOPPED	NEXT LID
Covering every missed shift herself.	Command, as the team grows.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which force do I use to hide the weakest one?

What would rise if this one lid were lifted?

Who could score me honestly?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
You do not rise to your goals. You rise to the level of your weakest force.

LEADERSHIP
A team rarely outperforms its leader for long. Raise yourself and you raise the ceiling for everyone.

BUSINESS
Before hiring more people or spending more on ads, check whether the founder is the bottleneck.

PERSONAL
Strength in one force is not permission to neglect another.

> *"Whatsoever thy hand findeth to do, do it with thy might."*
> ECCLESIASTES 9:10

PHOTO 03
Portrait, at least 1,300 × 2,800 px
Natural light or black and white

ON SEASONS

A TIME TO PUSH, A TIME TO HELP

When I competed, everything bent around one goal: training, food, sleep, even friendships. It was a season of unbalance, and I chose it. Then came a different season. I became a personal trainer and found that helping other people grow stronger meant more to me than any trophy.

I call it unbalance for the balance. You can push hard for a season if you know what it costs, protect what must not break, and know when the season ends.

Founders do not burn out because they work hard. They burn out because the push never ends. Choose your season. Then choose your restore.

ONE THING TO DO THIS WEEK
Write the name of your current season and its end date at the top of this week's calendar.

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CHECKPOINT

Pause before you go on. Four frameworks in, which one will change your next 30 days?

FRAMEWORK	USED IT	HOW MUCH IT FITS NOW, 1-5	ONE ACTION AND A DATE
The 10-5-3-1 Goal Ladder Page 8	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
The P.A.C.E. Decision Loop Page 10	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
Be, Do, Have, Become Page 12	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
The Five Forces Page 14	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	

THE ONE FRAMEWORK I WILL USE THIS MONTH, AND WHY

PAUSE	ASSESS	CHOOSE	EXECUTE
What is really happening?	Facts, options, costs	One option, and why	First step and date

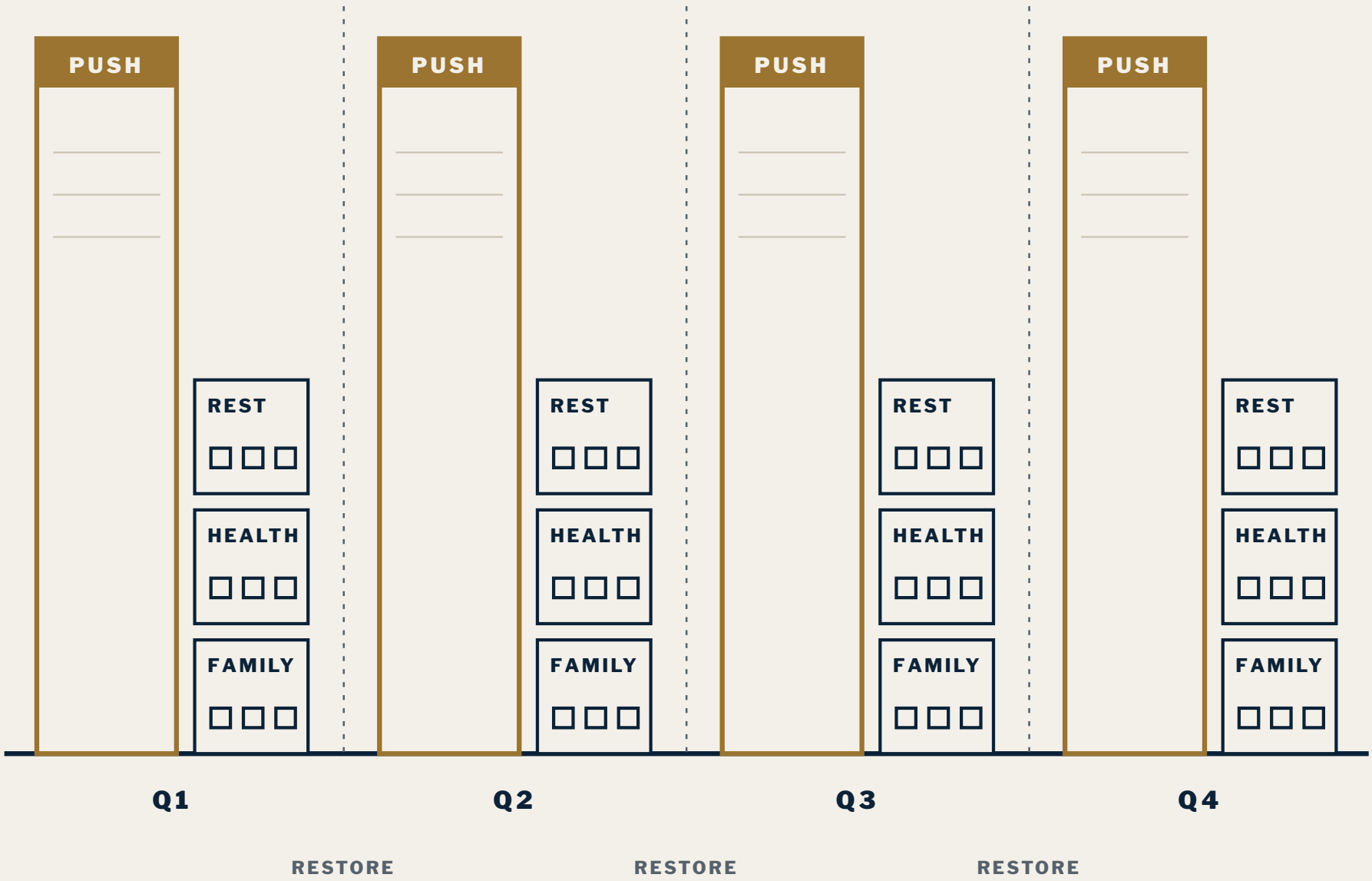
FIELD NOTES

UNBALANCE FOR THE BALANCE

> *Balance is not doing everything a little every day. It is choosing one season to push hard, protecting what must not break, and then restoring.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL

ONE PUSH PER SEASON. PROTECT THE REST.



1 One push per season, in the gold column.

2 Tick each minimum you kept that week.

☐ Small squares: weekly ticks for each minimum ■ Gold column: the season's one push

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

30 minutes before each quarter · 2 minutes every Sunday to tick the minimums

1. **Choose the season's push.** One priority for the next 90 days that deserves extra hours: a launch, a hire, a move.
2. **Set the minimums.** For family, health and rest, write the least you will keep, e.g. dinner at home four nights a week.
3. **Tell the people affected.** Unbalance with consent is a plan. Unbalance without it is neglect.
4. **Watch the warning lights.** If a minimum fails two weeks in a row, the push pauses until it is repaired.
5. **Restore before the next push.** Close each season with a lighter week and a review with P.A.C.E.

WORKED EXAMPLE — Tomás, 39 · logistics start-up in Madrid · 6 people

Q1 PUSH	Close the seed round: 60-hour weeks for ten weeks.
MINIMUMS	Sundays with family, three runs a week, seven hours' sleep.
WARNING	Week 7: two Sundays missed. He cancelled two investor calls.
RESTORE	One quiet week in April before the hiring push.

AGREED AT HOME
Ten weeks, not ten months.

NEXT SEASON
Hiring, with the same minimums.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which season am I in right now, and did I choose it?

What will I protect even in the hardest push?

When did I last restore?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Everything has a season. Trouble starts when a season never ends.

LEADERSHIP
Tell your team which season you are in. People can sprint when they can see the finish line.

BUSINESS
Concentration wins. Spreading effort evenly across ten priorities guarantees ten average results.

PERSONAL
Your family should not pay for a push they never agreed to.

> *"To every thing there is a season, and a time to every purpose under the heaven."*
> ECCLESIASTES 3:1

PAIRS WITH THE 10-5-3-1 GOAL LADDER (P. 8) · THE CEO'S FOUR BOXES (P. 22) · 19

ROOTS AND FRUITS

> *Every result you want is the fruit of a root you can train. When you are stuck, stop staring at the fruit. Look down, find the weakest root, and strengthen it.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL, FROM THE ALLOW YOURSELF TO RISE WORKBOOK

1 Score every cell from 1 to 5.

2 Read each column from the bottom up.

GROWTH the fruits	**PURPOSE** ☐☐☐☐☐	**STRUCTURE** ☐☐☐☐☐	**WISDOM** ☐☐☐☐☐	**RESULTS** ☐☐☐☐☐	**SERVICE** ☐☐☐☐☐	**LEGACY** ☐☐☐☐☐
MASTERY the stems	**MEANING** ☐☐☐☐☐	**CREATIVITY** ☐☐☐☐☐	**KNOWLEDGE** ☐☐☐☐☐	**ACTION** ☐☐☐☐☐	**ENERGY AND FOCUS** ☐☐☐☐☐	**MISSION** ☐☐☐☐☐
DISCOVERY the roots	**IDENTITY** ☐☐☐☐☐	**IMAGINATION** ☐☐☐☐☐	**INFORMATION** ☐☐☐☐☐	**UNDERSTANDING** ☐☐☐☐☐	**VALUES** ☐☐☐☐☐	**VISION** ☐☐☐☐☐

ROOTS FEED FRUITS

1 · QUESTION

Write the problem as one question aimed at an outcome.

2 · WEAKEST RING

Score each cell 1-5. Find the lowest in the column.

3 · OUTCOME

A real answer meets your standards, needs and desires.

☐ Squares: score each cell from 1 to 5 ■ Gold row: the fruits you can see

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

40 minutes · use it whenever you feel stuck · re-score in 90 days

1. **Ask one question.** Write the problem as one sentence aimed at an outcome: How do I double repeat sales this year?
2. **Score the map.** Rate each of the 18 cells from 1 to 5. Be strict; nobody else needs to see it.
3. **Find the weakest ring.** Follow the column under your problem, from the fruit down. The lowest cell is where the chain breaks.
4. **Strengthen it, or its neighbours.** Train the weak cell directly, or lean on the strong cells beside it while it grows.
5. **Test the outcome.** A real solution meets three tests: your standards (values), your needs and your desires.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Jonas, 47 · family bakery in Munich · 3 shops

QUESTION	Why does profit stay flat while sales grow?	
FRUIT	RESULTS	Sales up 15%, profit flat for two years.
STEM	ACTION	He works the ovens daily; nobody reviews costs.
ROOT	UNDERSTANDING	He has never read his own monthly accounts.

WHAT HE DID
A monthly hour with his accountant.

SIX MONTHS LATER
Profit up 9%.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which fruit am I trying to force without feeding the root?

Where is my lowest score, and what does it cost me?

Which strong cell can carry me while a weak one grows?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Look down to grow up. The roots decide the fruit long before the harvest.

LEADERSHIP
When a team underperforms, ask which root was never planted: clarity, skills or trust.

BUSINESS
Symptoms live in the results row. Causes live two rows below.

PERSONAL
Strengths are neighbours, not substitutes. Lean on them while you fix the weak link.

> *"Ye shall know them by their fruits."*
> MATTHEW 7:16

THE CEO'S FOUR BOXES

> *Urgent is loud. Important is quiet. A founder's week is won or lost in the quiet box: the work nobody will chase you for.*

BUILDS ON THE URGENT-IMPORTANT PRINCIPLE ATTRIBUTED TO DWIGHT D. EISENHOWER AND POPULARISED BY STEPHEN R. COVEY

IMPORTANCE

IMPORTANT

NOT IMPORTANT

PLAN Strategy, people, health, systems. Book it first.	**DO** Real crises and deadlines. Do now, then ask why it became urgent.
DROP Scrolling, busy work, meetings without purpose.	**DELEGATE** Interruptions others can handle. Hand over with a clear standard.

NOT URGENT — URGENCY — URGENT

☐ Write this week's tasks in the boxes ■ Gold box: the work that builds next year

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

20 minutes every Monday · 5 minutes on Friday to find the cause of this week's fires

1. **Empty your head.** List everything on your plate this week: tasks, calls, worries and ideas.
2. **Sort into four boxes.** Important means it moves your one-year goal. Urgent means someone is waiting today.
3. **Book the PLAN box first.** Put two or three blocks in your calendar before anyone else can take the time.
4. **Hand over and drop.** Delegate with a standard and a deadline. Delete what does not deserve you.
5. **Shrink the DO box.** Every Friday ask: which urgent item could have been planned? Fix that cause.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Hannah, 31 · marketing agency in Dublin · 8 people
DO	A client's campaign broke on launch day.
PLAN	Pricing review and hiring a senior designer, booked Tuesdays 8-10.
DELEGATE	Invoices and social replies to her assistant, with templates.
DROP	Three weekly calls with no agenda.

TIME WON BACK	CAUSE FIXED
Seven hours a week.	A launch checklist for every campaign.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

What important work have I postponed for more than a month?

Which urgent fire keeps returning, and why?

What would I drop if I had to cut ten hours a week?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Time is the only asset you cannot buy back. Spend it like capital.

LEADERSHIP
If everything is urgent for you, it is chaos for your team.

BUSINESS
The PLAN box is where next year's profit is built: pricing, people and systems.

PERSONAL
Health and family live in the PLAN box. They never shout until it is too late.

> *"Nothing, Lucilius, is ours, except time."*
> SENECA, LETTERS TO LUCILIUS

THE M.O.S.T. OPERATING CODE

> *Nobody can do your discipline for you. Write the code you live by, score yourself honestly, and train the three lowest traits.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL: M.O.S.T., MASTERING ONESELF TRAINING

CODE shows up daily	CONFIDENCE □□□□□	ORDER □□□□□	DEVOTION □□□□□	EXECUTION □□□□□

MISSION gives direction	MEANING □□□□□	INITIATIVE □□□□□	SELF-RESPECT □□□□□	SELF-DISCIPLINE □□□□□	INTEGRITY □□□□□	PRINCIPLES □□□□□	NAVIGATION □□□□□

CORE keeps you stable	CLARITY □□□□□	OWNERSHIP □□□□□	RESILIENCE □□□□□	EMOTIONAL COMMAND □□□□□

BUILT FROM THE GROUND UP

1 Score each of the 15 traits from 1 to 5.

2 Circle your three lowest traits.

□ Squares: score each trait from 1 to 5 ■ Gold tier: what people see from you every day

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

25 minutes · score this month's actions, not your intentions · re-score monthly

1. **Start at the core.** Score clarity, ownership, resilience and emotional command. They hold everything else up.
2. **Score the mission.** Seven traits that give direction. Score from what you did this month.
3. **Score the code.** Confidence, order, devotion and execution: what people see from you every day.
4. **Train the three lowest.** One small daily practice for each. Soft is not timid; fierce is not arrogant.
5. **Re-score monthly.** Keep the sheets. Your code becomes visible in the numbers.

WORKED EXAMPLE — David, 28 · first-time founder, fitness app · solo

LOWEST	CORE	Ownership 2: blamed the developer for a missed launch.
LOWEST	MISSION	Self-discipline 2: worked only when he felt like it.
LOWEST	CODE	Order 1: no calendar, no task list.
PRACTICE	Plan at 8:00 every day, review every Friday, own every deadline.	

AFTER 60 DAYS
App launched; three traits at 4.

NEXT
Initiative: 20 user interviews.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which trait do I expect from my team but not from myself?

Where am I soft when I should be firm, or harsh when I should be kind?

What would my code look like written on one page?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Discipline is the one mission you can never outsource.

LEADERSHIP
Your code is the first draft of your culture. People copy what you repeat.

BUSINESS
Investors back founders, not ideas. Your code is what they are really assessing.

PERSONAL
Strong and kind are not opposites. Mastery holds both.

> *"He that hath no rule over his own spirit is like a city that is broken down, and without walls."*
> PROVERBS 25:28

PHOTO 04
Portrait, at least 1,300 × 2,800 px
Natural light or black and white

ON PEOPLE

NOBODY RISES ALONE

When I arrived in Rome, I had more ambition than direction. My first coach became my mentor and something close to a father to me. He did not give me answers. He asked better questions and expected me to keep my word.

Every leader I admire has someone like that behind them. And every strong business is, in the end, a group of people who trust each other enough to be honest.

This part is about trust, feedback, emotion, communication, delegation and culture: the work of leading others. It is harder than leading yourself, because other people are not you. That is exactly why it matters.

ONE THING TO DO THIS WEEK
Send a message today to someone who helped you rise. Tell them what they changed.

Alexandru
ALEXANDRU COJOCARI · ROME



02

PEOPLE

LEAD PEOPLE

Who am I for others, and who are they to me?

Trust, feedback, emotion, communication, delegation and culture: the work of leading others.

09 The Trust Equation 28

10 Kind and Clear 30

11 The Reset 32

12 Point, Proof, Path 34

13 The Delegation Ladder 38

14 The Good People Company 40

15 Check the Story 42

16 Vision, Road, Team, People 44

THE TRUST EQUATION

> *Trust is the currency of every deal and every team. It rises with credibility, reliability and closeness, and falls with every sign that it is all about you.*

BUILDS ON THE TRUST EQUATION OF DAVID MAISTER, CHARLES GREEN AND ROBERT GALFORD, THE TRUSTED ADVISOR (2000)

CREDIBILITY
Do they believe what I say?
□□□□□

+

RELIABILITY
Do I do what I promise?
□□□□□

+

CLOSENESS
Do they feel safe with me?
□□□□□

=

TRUST
?

÷

SELF-FOCUS
How much is it about me?
□□□□□

1 **Score each part from 1 to 5,** from their point of view.

2 **Self-focus divides everything.** Lower it first.

□ Squares: score each part from 1 to 5 ■ Gold box: the part that divides the rest

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

15 minutes per relationship · before an important meeting or renewal

1. **Pick one relationship.** A key client, partner, investor or team member. Trust is always specific.
2. **Score the top line.** Credibility, reliability and closeness, from 1 to 5, as they would score you.
3. **Score your self-focus.** How often do you talk about yourself, push your agenda or rush to sell? Be honest.
4. **Lift the lowest top term.** Keep one small promise this week, share one useful insight, or ask one real question.
5. **Lower self-focus.** In your next meeting, speak last, ask more, and solve their problem before yours.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Pierre, 52 · IT consultancy in Lyon · 20 people
CREDIBILITY	5: a strong technical team.
RELIABILITY	2: two missed deadlines this year.
CLOSENESS	3: he only calls when something breaks.
SELF-FOCUS	4: every meeting turns into an upsell.

WHAT HE CHANGED	RESULT
A monthly check-in, with no selling.	Contract renewed for three years.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Who trusts me less than I think, and why?

Which small promise did I break recently?

In my last meeting, whose interests did I serve first?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Trust is built in drops and lost in buckets.

LEADERSHIP
A team that trusts its leader forgives mistakes. A team that does not forgives nothing.

BUSINESS
Trust lowers the cost of every sale. Trusted firms close faster and argue less about price.

PERSONAL
Be the same person in the meeting and in the corridor.

> *"He that is faithful in that which is least is faithful also in much."*
> LUKE 16:10

KIND AND CLEAR

> *Clarity without care is cruelty. Care without clarity is cowardice. Good leaders say the hard thing, kindly and early.*

BUILDS ON KIM SCOTT'S RADICAL CANDOR (2017) · EXPLORASELF PRINCIPLE: ACHIEVEMENT IS AN ACT OF KINDNESS



☐ Write a recent conversation in the box it belonged to ■ Gold box: where great leaders live

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

10 minutes before any hard conversation · 5 minutes after it to plan the follow-up

1. **Name the conversation you are avoiding.** Write it in one line: Ana is late with every report.
2. **Check your care.** Before you speak, write what you want for that person, not only for the business.
3. **State the fact.** One observable fact and its impact, without labels. Not “you are lazy” but “three reports were late”.
4. **Ask, then agree.** Ask what is going on and listen fully. Agree one next step and one date.
5. **Follow up.** Return on that date. Kindness without follow-up turns back into softness.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Giulia, 35 · restaurant owner in Florence · 15 staff
AVOIDING	Her head chef shouts at junior staff during service.
CARE	She wants him to stay and to lead, not to be feared.
FACT	Two cooks quit in March, and both named the shouting.
AGREED	Calm service for 30 days, with weekly coaching from her.

BEFORE	AFTER
Six months of silence.	No departures since May.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Who on my team deserves a clearer truth from me?

Am I soft because I care, or because I fear their reaction?

When did someone’s hard truth change my life?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Helping someone grow sometimes means telling them what they do not want to hear. That is kindness.

LEADERSHIP
Silence is a decision. People notice what you tolerate.

BUSINESS
Every month of unspoken feedback costs you in mistakes, turnover and lost clients.

PERSONAL
Ask for feedback before you give it. It earns you the right.

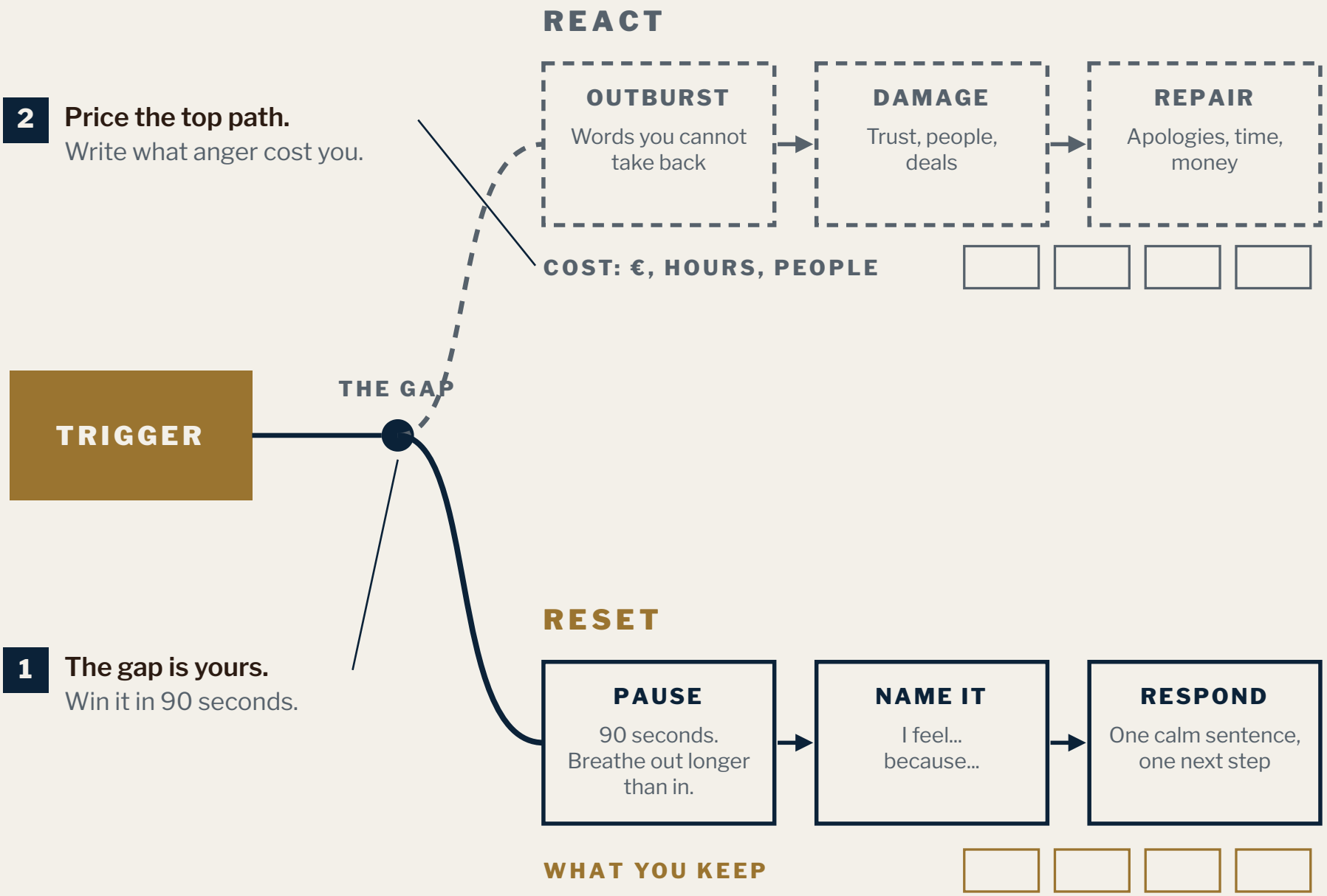
> *“Iron sharpeneth iron; so a man sharpeneth the countenance of his friend.”*
> PROVERBS 27:17

THE RESET

> *Anger is expensive. Every outburst has a price in trust, talent and clients. Command your emotion before it commands your business.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL, FROM THE EMOTIONAL COMMAND RESET

2 **Price the top path.**
Write what anger cost you.



1 **The gap is yours.**
Win it in 90 seconds.

☐ Dashed path: the reaction and its cost ■ Solid path: the reset and what it keeps

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

10 minutes after any outburst · 90 seconds in the moment · read your triggers every Monday

1. **Know your triggers.** List three situations that make you react: lateness, disrespect, bad numbers.
2. **Price the last outburst.** What did it cost in money, hours of repair and people? Write the real figure.
3. **Use the 90 seconds.** When triggered, stop and breathe out slowly. Do not type, send or decide.
4. **Name it, then respond.** Say: I am angry because the order is late. Then give one calm next step.
5. **Repair fast when you slip.** Apologise within 24 hours, without excuses. Then fix the cause, not the person.

WORKED EXAMPLE — Mihai, 45 · car repair workshop in Chișinău · 7 mechanics

TRIGGER	A mechanic hands back a car that is still leaking oil.
LAST TIME	He shouted in front of the client, and the mechanic resigned.
THE PRICE	€4,000 to hire and train, two weeks of lost work, one bad review.
NOW	Ninety seconds, then: “Show me what happened. Let’s fix it.”

KEPT
His best mechanic and the client.

CAUSE FIXED
A final check before every handover.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

What did my last outburst really cost?

Which trigger keeps catching me, and what is it protecting?

Who deserves an apology from me this week?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Fierce is not arrogant and calm is not weak. Strength is choosing your response.

LEADERSHIP
People rarely leave a company. They leave the way they were spoken to.

BUSINESS
Calculate the return on calm: every outburst avoided saves trust, time and talent.

PERSONAL
Anger is information, not instruction. Listen to it, then choose.

> *“He that is slow to anger is better than the mighty; and he that ruleth his spirit than he that taketh a city.”*
> PROVERBS 16:32

POINT, PROOF, PATH

> *If they cannot repeat it, you did not say it. Every message that matters needs one point, one proof and one path.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL

BEFORE EVERY MEETING, EMAIL, PITCH OR POST

POINT	PROOF	PATH
ONE SENTENCE What must they remember if they forget everything else?	**STORY OR NUMBER** One example, figure or story that makes it believable.	**THE NEXT STEP** What exactly do you want them to do, and by when?

1 **Write the point first:**
twelve words or fewer.

2 **End on the path.**
A message without an ask is a lecture.

☐ Write each part before you speak or send ■ Gold box: the action you ask for

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

5 minutes before any message that matters · say it aloud once before you send it

1. **Know your listener.** Who is it for, and what do they care about? Write that before anything else.
2. **Write the point.** One sentence, twelve words or fewer. If you need two, you have two messages.
3. **Choose one proof.** A number, a short story or a customer's words. One strong proof beats five weak ones.
4. **Give a clear path.** One action, one owner, one date. Make it easy to say yes.
5. **Test it.** Ask someone to repeat your point back. If they cannot, cut until they can.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Ana, 29 · business software start-up in Cluj · raising €300,000
POINT	We cut invoice errors for small firms by 80%.
PROOF	42 paying firms; one saved €11,000 in its first year.
PATH	Join our round by 30 June, with a €25,000 minimum.
BEFORE	Her old deck had 31 slides and no clear ask.

PITCH LENGTH	RESULT
From 20 minutes to 6.	Round closed in nine weeks.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

What is the one sentence my team should repeat about our direction?

Which proof do I use that nobody remembers?

Where do I talk without asking for anything?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Clear thinking comes before clear speaking. Confusion on paper becomes confusion in the room.

LEADERSHIP
Repeat the point until you are tired of it. That is when your team has just started to hear it.

BUSINESS
Sales, fundraising and hiring are the same skill: one point, one proof, one path.

PERSONAL
Say less, mean more. People trust the speaker who knows when to stop.

> *"For if the trumpet give an uncertain sound, who shall prepare himself to the battle?"*
> 1 CORINTHIANS 14:8

PHOTO 05
Portrait, at least 1,300 × 2,800 px
Natural light or black and white

ON KINDNESS

ACHIEVEMENT IS AN ACT OF KINDNESS

I used to think kindness meant being nice. Then I watched good people stay stuck because nobody told them the truth, sometimes including me.

Real kindness wants the other person to grow. Sometimes it sounds like encouragement. Sometimes it sounds like: this is not good enough yet, and I believe you can do better.

When you reach a goal, you show the people around you what is possible. When you help them reach theirs, you multiply it. That is why I believe achievement is an act of kindness.

ONE THING TO DO THIS WEEK
Have the honest, kind conversation you have been postponing.

Alexandru
ALEXANDRU COJOCARI · ROME

CHECKPOINT

Pause before you go on. Four frameworks in, which one will change your next 30 days?

FRAMEWORK	USED IT	HOW MUCH IT FITS NOW, 1-5	ONE ACTION AND A DATE
The Trust Equation Page 28	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
Kind and Clear Page 30	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
The Reset Page 32	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
Point, Proof, Path Page 34	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	

THE ONE FRAMEWORK I WILL USE THIS MONTH, AND WHY

PAUSE	ASSESS	CHOOSE	EXECUTE
What is really happening?	Facts, options, costs	One option, and why	First step and date

FIELD NOTES

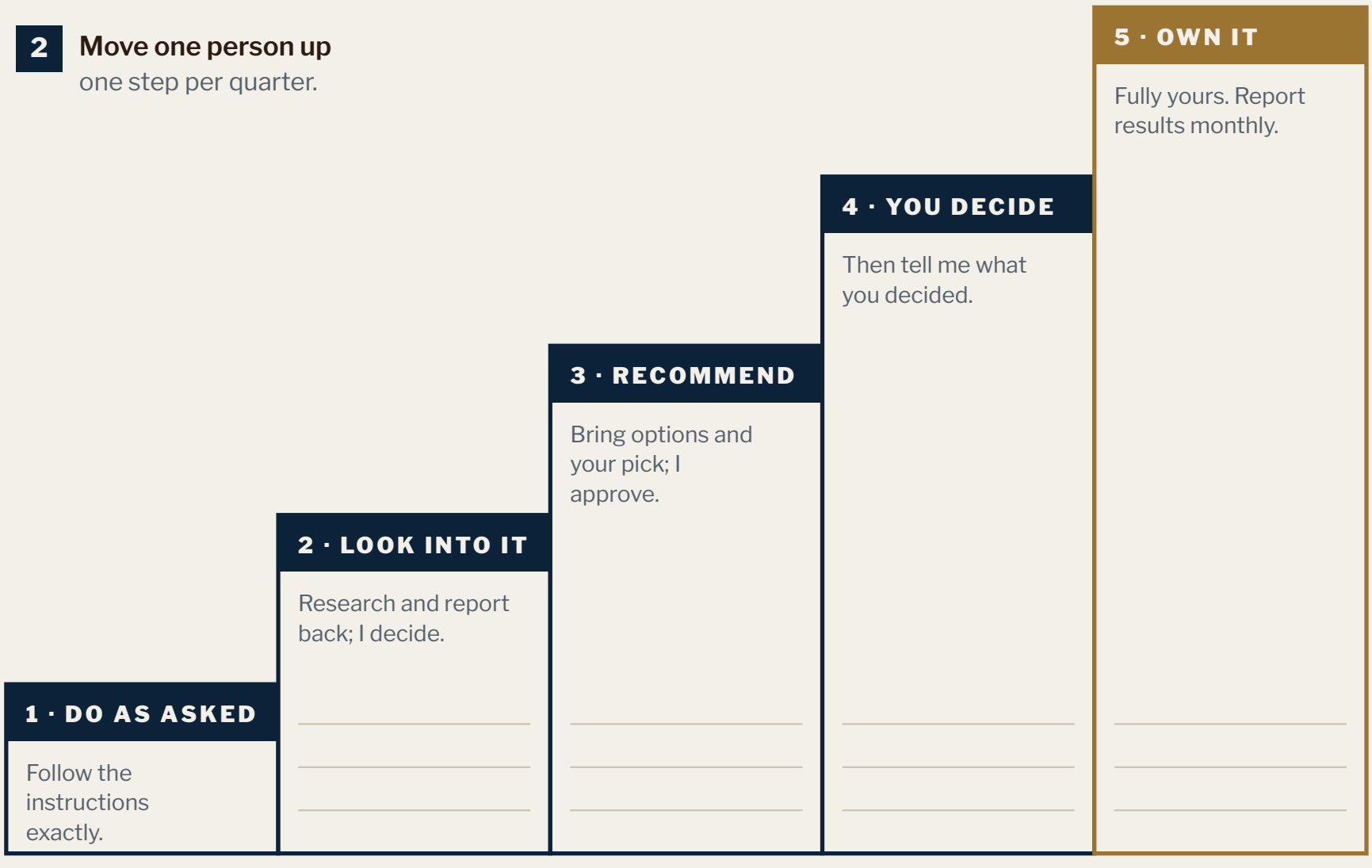
THE DELEGATION LADDER

> *You cannot scale what you will not hand over. Delegate in steps: authority grows as trust is proven.*

BUILDS ON THE LEVELS OF DELEGATION LONG USED IN MANAGEMENT PRACTICE

1 **Write a task and a name**
on the right step.

2 **Move one person up**
one step per quarter.



☐ Write a task and a person on each step ■ Gold step: full ownership

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

30 minutes once a month · say the step out loud every time you hand something over

1. **List what only you do.** Every recurring task you still handle. Mark the ones someone else could learn.
2. **Choose the step.** For each task and person, pick a step on the ladder, and say the step out loud.
3. **Set the standard.** Define what good looks like: a checklist, an example, a deadline, a budget limit.
4. **Check, then step back.** Review closely at first. When the standard holds three times, move up one step.
5. **Resist taking it back.** When it is done 80% as well as you would do it, let it be. Coach the other 20%.

WORKED EXAMPLE — Karim, 41 · online furniture brand in Marseille · 12 people

TASK	Customer refunds, all signed by Karim.
STEP 2	Léa researched each case and reported back for four weeks.
STEP 4	Now she decides up to €300 and tells him weekly.
HIS TIME	Five hours a week back for supplier talks.

NEXT STEP
Léa owns refunds fully in Q3.

STANDARD
Refund checklist, €300 limit.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

What am I still doing that someone else could do at 80%?

Who on my team is ready for the next step up?

Do I delegate tasks, or also the authority to decide?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Trust is earned in small things before it is given in large ones.

LEADERSHIP
Delegation is service: it makes your people grow, not only your calendar lighter.

BUSINESS
Your hourly value as founder is your yearly goal divided by your working hours. Delegate everything below it.

PERSONAL
Control feels safe, but it keeps you small and tired.

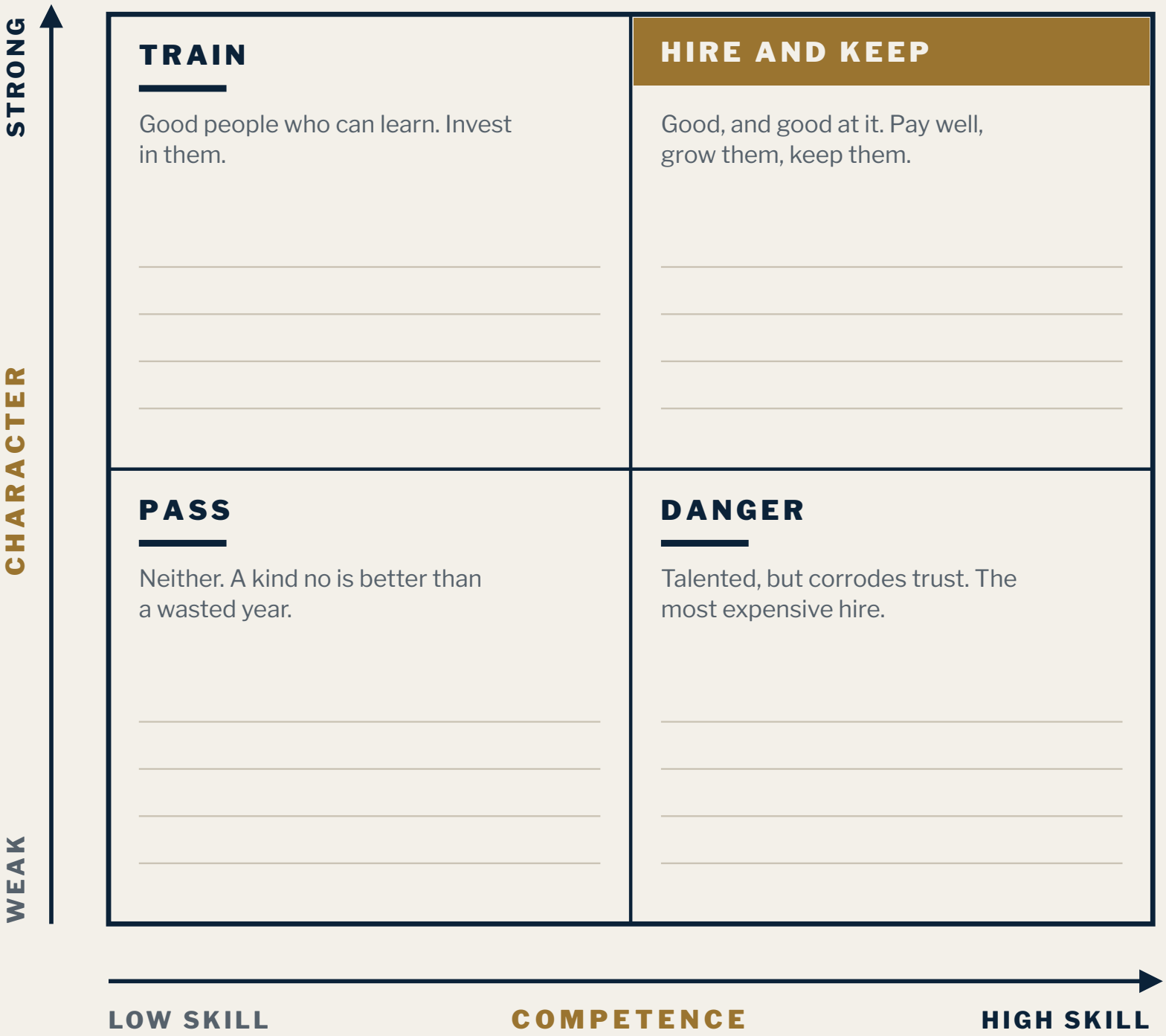
> *"Whosoever will be great among you, shall be your minister."*
> MARK 10:43

PAIRS WITH THE CEO'S FOUR BOXES (P. 22) · BUILD, GROW, SCALE (P. 52) · 39

THE GOOD PEOPLE COMPANY

> *Build a company of good people who are good at what they do. Hire for character, train for skill, and never keep talent that poisons trust.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL · ECHOES THE IDEA THAT TRUST NEEDS BOTH CHARACTER AND COMPETENCE



☐ Write each person's initials in one box ■ Gold box: the people you build on

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

45 minutes twice a year · before every hire · after every resignation

1. **Define good in your company.** Three behaviours you will never compromise on, e.g. tells the truth, keeps promises, helps others win.
2. **Place your team honestly.** Put each person in one box based on what they do, not what they say.
3. **Invest in TRAIN.** Give good people a skill plan, a mentor and 90 days to grow.
4. **Act on DANGER.** Talk clearly and set one deadline for change. If the behaviour stays, part with respect.
5. **Hire for both.** In interviews, test character with real stories and skill with a real task.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Stefan, 50 · engineering firm in Vienna · 40 people
DANGER	His top salesman hit every target and belittled colleagues.
THE COST	Two engineers left; support staff avoided his clients.
DECISION	A clear warning, 60 days to change, then a respectful exit.
AFTER	Team sales rose 12% within a year.

VALUES WRITTEN	HIRING CHANGE
Truth, promises, help others win.	A paid trial task for every candidate.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Who is in the danger box, and what is my silence costing?

Which good person deserves more training from me?

Would I hire myself into this company today?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Good people make good companies. Policies cannot replace character.

LEADERSHIP
Your culture is the worst behaviour you tolerate.

BUSINESS
Character problems scale faster than revenue. Fix them while the company is small.

PERSONAL
Be the kind of person you want to hire.

> *"A good name is rather to be chosen than great riches."*
> PROVERBS 22:1

PAIRS WITH KIND AND CLEAR (P. 30) · THE LEGACY TEST (P. 84) · 41

CHECK THE STORY

> *We see a fact, add a story and act as if the story were true. Before you react, climb down the ladder and check.*

BUILDS ON THE LADDER OF INFERENCE BY CHRIS ARGYRIS, POPULARISED BY PETER SENGE

BELIEFS FILTER WHAT WE SEE

I ACT What I do next		I will:
I BELIEVE My view of them		I believe:
I CONCLUDE My verdict		So:
I ASSUME What I take for granted		I assume:
I ADD MEANING My interpretation		It means:
I NOTICE The part I picked out		I noticed:
FACTS What a camera would record		What happened:

1 Start at the bottom: facts only.

2 Ask: what else could be true?

☐ Boxes: write each rung of your story ■ Gold rung: the action, decided last

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

5 minutes whenever you feel certain and annoyed at the same time

1. **Catch the jump.** Notice when you feel certain and annoyed at once. That is usually a story.
2. **Go back to the facts.** Write only what a camera would have recorded. No adjectives.
3. **Find two other stories.** List two other explanations that fit the same facts.
4. **Test with a question.** Ask the person: I noticed this. What happened? Then listen to the whole answer.
5. **Act on what you learned.** Decide after the facts are clear, not before.

WORKED EXAMPLE — Laura, 38 · partner in an accounting firm in Brussels

FACTS	A client did not reply to two emails in ten days.
HER STORY	They are unhappy and talking to a competitor.
OTHER STORIES	On holiday. Busy year-end. Emails in spam.
SHE ASKED	A short call: the client had been in hospital and was grateful for it.

AVOIDED	NEW HABIT
A defensive discount offer.	Ask before assuming.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which story about a colleague have I never checked?

What facts would change my mind?

Where do my beliefs filter what I am able to see?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
As a man thinks, so is he. The stories you tell shape the world you see.

LEADERSHIP
Most team conflict is two people acting on two different stories about the same fact.

BUSINESS
Bad decisions often start with a confident assumption nobody wrote down.

PERSONAL
Hold your first story lightly. It is a guess, not a verdict.

> *"He that answereth a matter before he heareth it, it is folly and shame unto him."*
> **PROVERBS 18:13**

VISION, ROAD, TEAM, PEOPLE

> *People follow a leader who answers four questions: where are we going, how do we get there, who comes with us, and does each person grow on the way?*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL

VISION

Where are we going, and why does it matter?

ROAD

How do we get there, step by step?

TEAM

Who goes with us, in which role?

PEOPLE

Does each person grow here?

1 Answer from the top down.

2 Test from the bottom up.

☐ Lines: one clear answer per level ■ Gold level: the vision everything serves

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

One hour each quarter with your team · ask them to answer before you do

1. **Write the vision.** One sentence about where you will be in three to five years and why it matters to clients.
2. **Draw the road.** Three to five milestones with dates. People need to see the next stop, not only the summit.
3. **Design the team.** List the roles the road needs. Put names in them and mark the empty seats.
4. **Grow the people.** For each person: one skill to build this year and one conversation about their own goals.
5. **Tell it often.** Share all four answers every quarter, and ask the team to repeat them back.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Raluca, 34 · physiotherapy clinics in Iași · 16 people
VISION	The sports clinic athletes in north-east Romania trust most, by 2030.
ROAD	A third clinic in 2027, club partnerships in 2028, a training academy in 2029.
TEAM	Needs a clinic manager and a head of education.
PEOPLE	Each physio picks a specialism and gets a course budget.

TEAM CHANGE	STAFF TURNOVER
Two physios applied to lead.	Down from 30% to 8%.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Could my team repeat our vision in one sentence?

Which empty seat on the road am I filling myself?

Who is growing here, and who is only working?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Two are better than one. Great work is always done by people together.

LEADERSHIP
Vision attracts people. Growth keeps them.

BUSINESS
A road with dates turns a dream into a plan that investors and employees can believe.

PERSONAL
Ask your people about their goals, not only their tasks.

> *"Where there is no vision, the people perish."*
> PROVERBS 29:18

PHOTO 06
Portrait, at least 1,300 × 2,800 px
Natural light or black and white

ON THE BUSINESS

BUSINESS IS LIFE, AND LIFE IS BUSINESS

I studied business and management, but my best business lessons came from mistakes: late orders, thin margins and promises I could not keep.

The way you run your day is the way you run your company. If you avoid your numbers at home, you will avoid them at work. If you keep your word to your family, you will keep it to your clients.

This part covers the machine: your model, your stage, your money engines, your margins, your bottleneck, your goals and your biggest decisions. Treat it with the care you give your health.

ONE THING TO DO THIS WEEK
Book one hour this week to read your own numbers, with no interruptions.

Alexandru
ALEXANDRU COJOCARI · ROME



03

WORK

LEAD THE BUSINESS

What do I truly care about, and does it pay?

Your model, stage, money engines, margins, bottleneck, goals and the decisions that shape them.

17 The Four P's 48

18 The Wisdom and Wealth Cross 50

19 Build, Grow, Scale 52

20 The Five Money Engines 54

21 The Profit Line 58

22 The Constraint 60

23 One Objective, Three Results 62

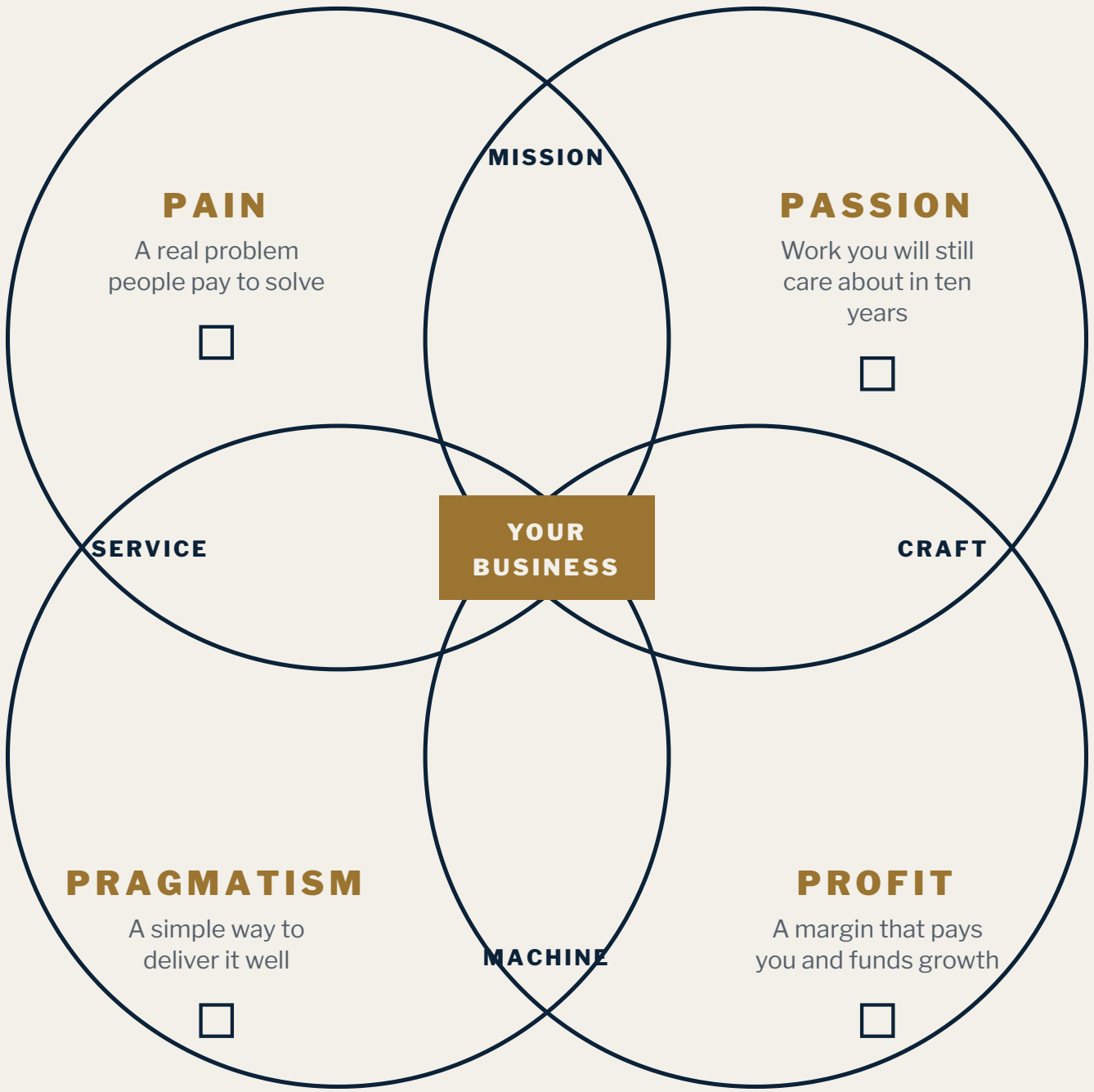
24 Decision Doors 64

THE FOUR P'S

> *A business that lasts sits where four things meet: a real pain, your passion, a pragmatic way to deliver, and profit. Take one away and it wobbles.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL

1 Tick the square of each P you can prove.



☐ Squares: tick each P you can prove with facts ■ Gold centre: where all four meet

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

40 minutes · before you launch, pivot or raise prices · repeat once a year

1. **Name the pain.** Write the problem in your client's words. If nobody would pay to fix it, it is not a pain.
2. **Check your passion.** Would you still want to solve this in ten years, on a bad Monday? Be honest.
3. **Make it pragmatic.** Describe the simplest way to deliver the result well with what you have today.
4. **Prove the profit.** Price minus the cost to deliver and to win a client. Write the margin per client.
5. **Fix the missing P.** Tick the circles you can prove. Your next 90 days go to the one you cannot tick.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Irina, 30 · wellbeing coach in Bucharest · from studio to companies
PAIN	Office teams with back pain and stress; HR has a budget for it.
PASSION	She loves teaching, much less running a studio rota.
PRAGMATISM	Two 45-minute sessions a week in each client's office.
PROFIT	€1,600 a month per company, at a 70% margin.

MISSING BEFORE	NOW
Profit: €8 studio classes.	Six company clients; weekends at the studio.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which of the four P's am I pretending is there?

Am I solving a pain, or selling my passion?

What is my real margin per client?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Passion starts a business. Pain and profit keep it alive.

LEADERSHIP
Explain the pain you solve to your team. People work harder when they can see who they help.

BUSINESS
Without profit a mission becomes a hobby. Without a mission profit becomes a job.

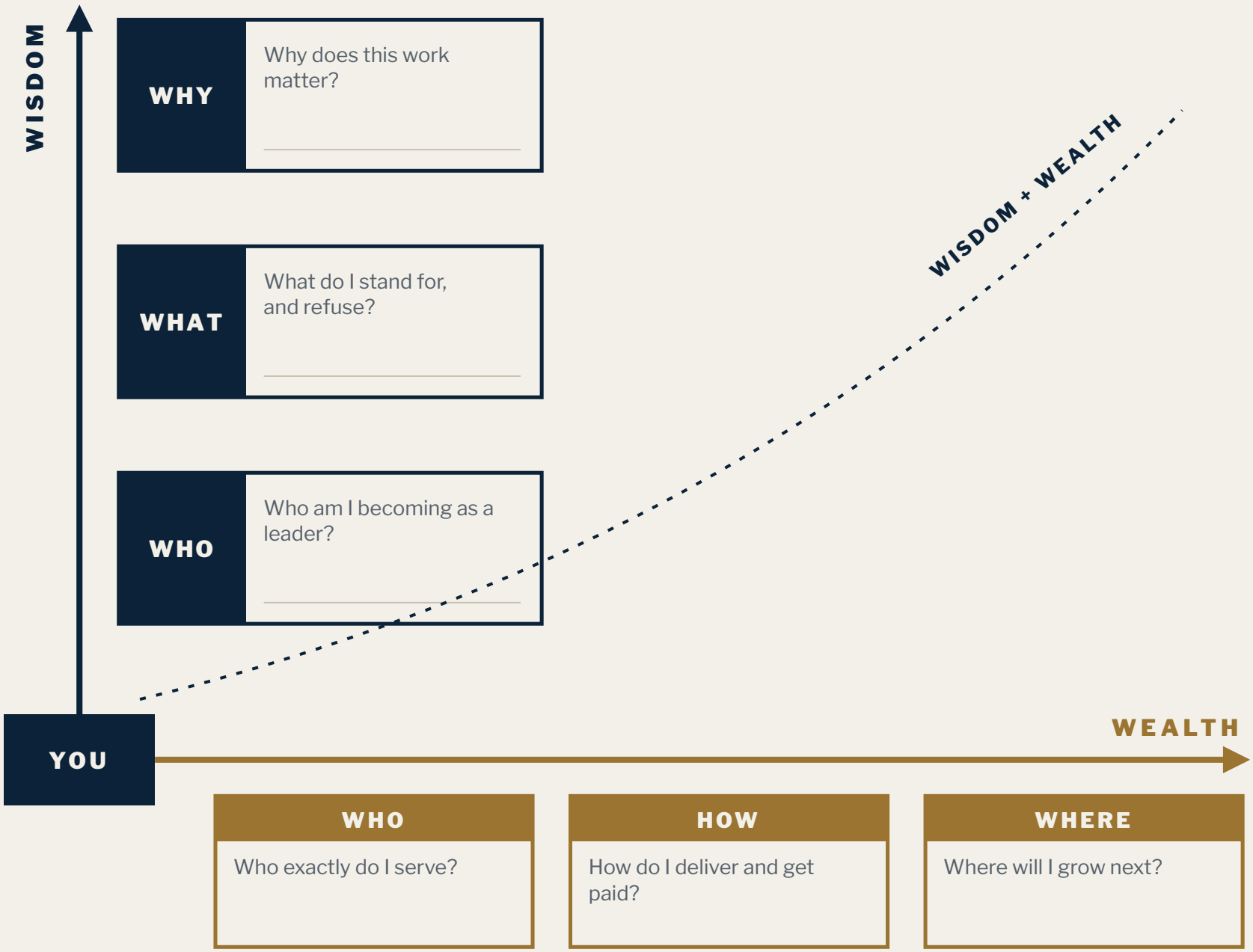
PERSONAL
Business is life and life is business. Choose work you can grow in, not only earn from.

> *"Through wisdom is an house builded; and by understanding it is established."*
> PROVERBS 24:3

THE WISDOM AND WEALTH CROSS

> *Wisdom grows upwards: why you do it, what you stand for, who you are. Wealth grows outwards: who you serve, how you deliver, where you grow. Build both, or the business leans.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL, FROM ALLOW YOURSELF TO RISE



1 **Fill the vertical first: wisdom.**

2 **Then the horizontal: wealth.**

Navy boxes: the wisdom axis Gold boxes: the wealth axis

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

30 minutes · whenever growth feels empty, or meaning does not pay

1. **Answer the three whys.** Why this work, what you stand for, and who you are becoming. One line each.
2. **Answer the three hows.** Who you serve, how you deliver and get paid, and where you will grow next.
3. **Check the balance.** Strong wisdom, weak wealth: a noble struggle. Strong wealth, weak wisdom: an empty success.
4. **Lift the weaker axis.** Pick one box on the shorter axis and work on it for 90 days.
5. **Make them talk.** Every growth decision must answer a why and a how. If it serves only one, wait.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Matteo, 42 · family wine estate in Piedmont
WISDOM	Why: keep his grandfather's vineyard alive. Clear and strong.
WEALTH	Who: everyone. How: wholesale at thin margins. Where: unclear.
THE CHANGE	Who: restaurants in Switzerland. How: direct sales at three times the margin.
TWO YEARS ON	Same vineyard, double the profit, one new hire.

WEAKER AXIS	DECISION FILTER
Wealth.	Does it honour the family, and does it pay?

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which axis am I proud of, and which do I avoid?

Could I explain my why to a client in one sentence?

Which way does my business lean?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Wisdom without wealth struggles to help. Wealth without wisdom forgets whom it was meant to help.

LEADERSHIP
Teams need both: a reason to care and a plan that pays.

BUSINESS
Purpose is a strategy only when it changes whom you serve and how you charge.

PERSONAL
Grow upwards before you grow outwards, or success will find you empty.

> *"Wisdom is the principal thing; therefore get wisdom: and with all thy getting get understanding."*
> PROVERBS 4:7

BUILD, GROW, SCALE

> *Each stage of a business asks for a different founder. What made you win at the start will hold you back later. Know your stage and change your role.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL, FROM UNBOUND

1 Mark where you are today.

2 Write what you must stop doing.

BUILD

YOU: THE DOER

Find a pain, sell it, deliver it yourself. Prove that people pay.

GROW

YOU: THE MANAGER

Repeat what works. Systems, first hires, steady cash.

SCALE

YOU: THE LEADER

Lead leaders. Vision, capital, culture.

YOUR ROLE MUST CHANGE AT EVERY STEP

☐ Lines: what this stage needs from you ■ Gold step: leaders under you

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

One hour once a year · and whenever you feel busier but not bigger

1. **Name your stage honestly.** Build: no repeatable sales yet. Grow: repeatable sales. Scale: leaders under you.
2. **List what the stage needs.** Three priorities for this stage only. Ignore advice meant for another stage.
3. **List what you must stop.** The habits that made you win before and now slow you down.
4. **Hire for the next step.** Your next key hire should take over the work you must stop doing.
5. **Review the stage every year.** Stages change quietly. A yearly check stops you running a Build company like a Scale one.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Nikos, 37 · coffee roastery in Athens · 9 people
STAGE	Grow: steady café clients, but Nikos still roasts every batch.
STOP	Roasting, delivering and approving every invoice himself.
HIRE	A head roaster, with his recipes written down.
NEXT	Time to win two export clients in Cyprus.

HARDEST PART	RESULT
Letting someone else roast.	Revenue up 40% the next year.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which stage am I really in?

Which favourite task does the business no longer need from me?

Who do I need to become for the next step?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Every new level asks for a new version of you.

LEADERSHIP
At Build you lead by example, at Grow by systems, at Scale through people.

BUSINESS
Advice depends on the stage. A Scale playbook can kill a Build company.

PERSONAL
Letting go of the work you love can be the most loving thing you do for the business.

> *"Prepare thy work without, and make it fit for thyself in the field; and afterwards build thine house."*
> PROVERBS 24:27

PAIRS WITH THE DELEGATION LADDER (P. 38) · THE FIVE MONEY ENGINES (P. 54) · 53

THE FIVE MONEY ENGINES

> *Every business runs on five engines: create value, attract attention, sell, deliver and manage money. Cash flows only as fast as the weakest one allows.*

EXPLORASELF, FROM UNBOUND · BUILDS ON THE FIVE PARTS OF EVERY BUSINESS IN JOSH KAUFMAN'S THE PERSONAL MBA

1 Score each engine from 1 to 5.

2 Fix the lowest link first.

CASH FLOWS THROUGH THE CHAIN

VALUE CREATION	MARKETING	SALES	VALUE DELIVERY	FINANCE
Make something people want and pay for	Attention from the right people	Turn interest into paid commitments	Keep the promise, every time	Cash, margin, reserves, reports
☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐

SCORE 1-5

WEAKEST LINK AND ONE FIX

☐ Squares: score each engine from 1 to 5 ■ Gold box: your weakest link and its fix

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

30 minutes each quarter · write one real number beside every score

1. **Score each engine.** Rate value, marketing, sales, delivery and finance from 1 to 5, with a real number beside each.
2. **Find the weakest link.** A great product with weak marketing earns nothing. The lowest score limits all the others.
3. **Pick one fix for 90 days.** One measurable change in the weakest engine only. Keep the others steady.
4. **Track one number per engine.** For example: repeat rate, leads, close rate, complaints, cash in the bank.
5. **Re-score each quarter.** As one link gets stronger, another becomes the weakest. That is normal growth.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Sara, 33 · online language school in Porto · 5 teachers
SCORES	Value 5, marketing 2, sales 4, delivery 4, finance 3.
WEAKEST	MARKETING Only 30 new leads a month, all from friends.
THE FIX	Two YouTube lessons a week for 90 days.
RESULT	140 leads a month. Finance is now the weakest link.

NUMBER TRACKED	NEXT FIX
Leads per month.	A monthly cash review.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which engine am I proud of, and which do I avoid looking at?

Which number tells me the health of each engine?

Where does cash get stuck in my business?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
A chain is only as strong as its weakest link. So is a business.

LEADERSHIP
Give each engine an owner, even if today every owner is you on a different day.

BUSINESS
Most struggling small firms do not have a product problem. They have a marketing or finance problem.

PERSONAL
We polish the engine we enjoy and neglect the one that scares us.

> *"In all labour there is profit: but the talk of the lips tendeth only to penury."*
> PROVERBS 14:23

PHOTO 07
Portrait, at least 1,300 × 2,800 px
Natural light or black and white

ON MONEY

THE 50/50 RULE

Early on I asked myself a simple question: should I do what I love or what pays? My answer became a rule: half what I am best at, half what the market will pay for, leaning towards profit by serving people well.

Profit is not greed. It is proof that you solved a real problem well enough that people paid for it, and it is the fuel that lets you serve more people tomorrow.

Stick to what you do best, and serve people. The money follows the service, not the other way round.

ONE THING TO DO THIS WEEK
Work out your profit per client with The Profit Line before you read on.

Alexandru
ALEXANDRU COJOCARI · ROME

CHECKPOINT

Pause before you go on. Four frameworks in, which one will change your next 30 days?

FRAMEWORK	USED IT	HOW MUCH IT FITS NOW, 1-5	ONE ACTION AND A DATE
The Four P's Page 48	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
The Wisdom and Wealth Cross Page 50	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
Build, Grow, Scale Page 52	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
The Five Money Engines Page 54	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	

THE ONE FRAMEWORK I WILL USE THIS MONTH, AND WHY

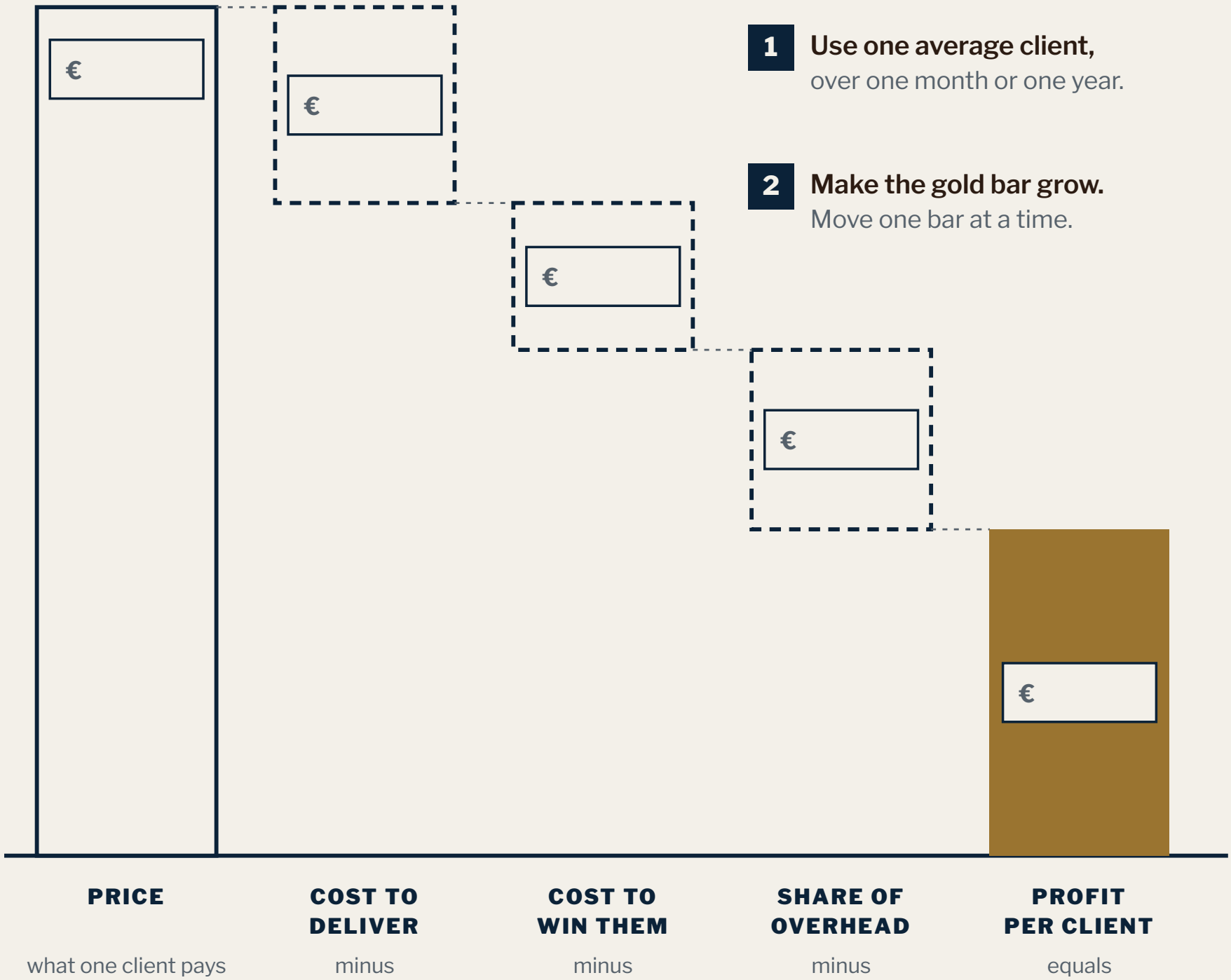
PAUSE	ASSESS	CHOOSE	EXECUTE
What is really happening?	Facts, options, costs	One option, and why	First step and date

FIELD NOTES

THE PROFIT LINE

> *Revenue is vanity until you know what each client leaves behind. Know the profit line of one client and you know your business.*

CLASSIC UNIT ECONOMICS, IN EXPLORASELF FORM



1 **Use one average client,**
over one month or one year.

2 **Make the gold bar grow.**
Move one bar at a time.

☐ Boxes: write the euro amount for each bar ■ Gold bar: what each client really leaves you

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

One hour with last year's numbers · repeat whenever you change prices

1. **Pick one average client.** Use last year's numbers. One month or one year, but the same period throughout.
2. **Write the price.** What that client really pays you after discounts and refunds.
3. **Subtract the true costs.** Delivery (materials, hours, tools), winning the client (ads, sales time) and a fair share of overhead.
4. **Read the gold bar.** If profit per client is thin or negative, more clients will make things worse, not better.
5. **Move one bar.** Raise the price, cut the cost to deliver or win clients more cheaply. Test one change at a time.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Lukas, 40 · web design studio in Prague · 6 people
PRICE	€6,000 per website.
DELIVERY	€3,900 in hours: projects ran 40% over.
WINNING	€900: long proposals and many free meetings.
PROFIT	€300 after overhead. Now €1,900 with fixed-scope packages.

CHANGE MADE	EFFECT
Fixed scope, paid first workshop.	Fewer clients for the same profit.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Do I know my profit per client, or only my revenue?

Which type of client makes me the most profit?

What would happen if I raised prices by 10%?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Clarity about money is a form of respect: for your clients, your team and yourself.

LEADERSHIP
Share the profit line with your team. People protect margins they understand.

BUSINESS
Growth with a negative profit line is just a faster way to fail.

PERSONAL
Know your numbers the way you know the names of your family.

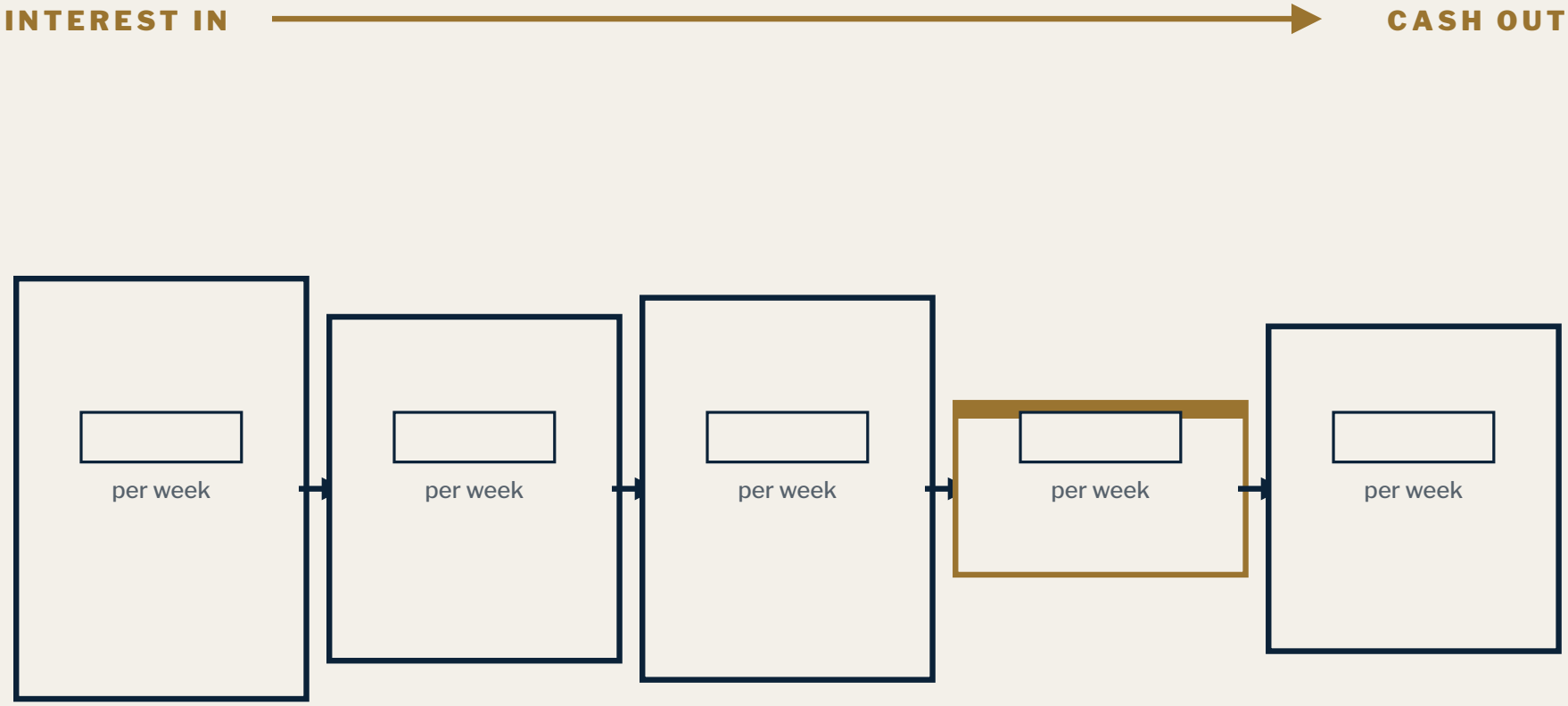
> *"For which of you, intending to build a tower, sitteth not down first, and counteth the cost, whether he have sufficient to finish it?"*
> LUKE 14:28

PAIRS WITH THE FIVE MONEY ENGINES (P. 54) · THE FOUR P'S (P. 48) · 59

THE CONSTRAINT

> *Every system has one bottleneck that sets its speed. Improve anything else and nothing changes. Find the narrowest point and widen it.*

BUILDS ON ELIYAHU M. GOLDRATT'S THEORY OF CONSTRAINTS, THE GOAL (1984)



1 **Write the weekly number in each pipe.**

2 **The narrowest pipe is your constraint.**

☐ Boxes: how many pass each stage per week ■ Gold edge: the narrowest pipe

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

One hour with real numbers · repeat whenever growth stalls

1. **Draw your flow.** Five stages from first interest to cash in the bank. Use your own words.
2. **Count the weekly flow.** How many pass through each stage per week? Write the real number in each pipe.
3. **Find the narrowest point.** The stage with the lowest capacity or the longest queue. Work piles up in front of it.
4. **Feed it and protect it.** Make sure the constraint never waits for work and never does work others can do.
5. **Widen it, then look again.** Add capacity there only. When it stops being the narrowest, a new constraint appears.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Ioana, 43 · kitchen installation company in Timișoara · 18 people
FLOW	40 leads, 15 visits, 8 sales and 4 installations a week.
CONSTRAINT	■ DELIVERY — Four installations a week; a seven-week waiting list.
WRONG FIX	More ads, which only made the waiting list longer.
RIGHT FIX	A second crew and pre-cut panels: seven installations a week.

CASH CYCLE	NEXT CONSTRAINT
From nine weeks to four.	Site visits.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Where does work pile up and wait in my business?

Am I improving a stage that is not the constraint?

What would double if the narrowest stage doubled?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Effort in the wrong place is just noise. Wisdom is knowing where to push.

LEADERSHIP
Protect the people who work at the constraint. Their hour is the whole company's hour.

BUSINESS
An hour lost at the bottleneck is lost for the whole business. An hour saved elsewhere is a mirage.

PERSONAL
Often the constraint is the founder's approval. Check your own desk first.

> *"A little neglect may breed great mischief."*
> BENJAMIN FRANKLIN, THE WAY TO WEALTH

ONE OBJECTIVE, THREE RESULTS

> *A team that chases ten goals reaches none. Set one objective for the quarter, three measurable results and the few actions that move them.*

BUILDS ON OBJECTIVES AND KEY RESULTS, FROM ANDY GROVE AT INTEL, POPULARISED BY JOHN DOERR

1 **Objective:**
inspiring, no numbers.

OBJECTIVE · THIS QUARTER

Where we want to be in 90 days, in plain words

_____

2 **Results:**
numbers with dates.

RESULT 1

How we will know:

from _____ to _____

by ____ / ____ / _____

ACTION A

_____

ACTION B

_____

RESULT 2

How we will know:

from _____ to _____

by ____ / ____ / _____

ACTION A

_____

ACTION B

_____

RESULT 3

How we will know:

from _____ to _____

by ____ / ____ / _____

ACTION A

_____

ACTION B

_____

REVIEW THE RESULTS EVERY FRIDAY · SCORE THEM AT 90 DAYS

☐ Boxes: three results, two actions each ■ Gold box: the one objective

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

Two hours at the start of each quarter · 15 minutes every Friday

1. **Write one objective.** Ambitious and clear, with no numbers: become the clinic our patients recommend first.
2. **Add three results.** Each one measurable: from X to Y by a date. If you cannot measure it, it is a task.
3. **Choose two actions per result.** The few things you will actually do. Everything else waits.
4. **Review every Friday.** Fifteen minutes: are the numbers moving, what is blocking them, who needs help?
5. **Score at 90 days.** From 0 to 1 for each result. 0.7 is a good score. Learn, then set the next quarter.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Clara, 46 · private kindergartens in Zurich · 3 sites
OBJECTIVE	Become the kindergarten parents recommend first.
RESULT 1	Parent satisfaction from 7.2 to 8.5 by 30 September.
RESULT 2	Waiting list from 12 to 40 families.
ACTIONS	A monthly parents' evening and a weekly photo update for each family.

SCORES AT 90 DAYS	NEXT QUARTER
0.8, 0.6 and 0.9.	A staff training objective.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

If we could achieve only one thing this quarter, what would it be?

Which of my goals are really tasks?

How will I know on the last day of the quarter that we succeeded?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Focus is saying no to good ideas so you can say yes to the right one.

LEADERSHIP
A clear objective lets people decide without you. That is real delegation.

BUSINESS
Measure results, not activity. Busy teams can still go nowhere.

PERSONAL
Celebrate a 0.7. Ambitious goals are meant to stretch you.

> *"Write the vision, and make it plain upon tables, that he may run that readeth it."*
> HABAKKUK 2:2

DECISION DOORS

> *Some decisions are doors you can walk back through. Others lock behind you. Decide fast on the first kind and slowly on the second.*

BUILDS ON JEFF BEZOS'S ONE-WAY AND TWO-WAY DOORS (AMAZON SHAREHOLDER LETTER, 2015) AND GARY KLEIN'S PRE-MORTEM



☐ Write each open decision in its box ■ Gold box: the decisions that deserve your time

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

10 minutes per decision · a full pre-mortem for anything in the gold box

1. **Name the decision.** Write it as a clear choice: sign a five-year lease on a bigger office, yes or no?
2. **Ask: can I undo it?** If yes, what would reversing it cost in time, money, trust and reputation?
3. **Ask: what is at stake?** Rate the downside if it goes wrong, from small to company-changing.
4. **Use the box's speed.** Quick on reversible ones; slow, consulted and written down on permanent, high-stakes ones.
5. **Run a pre-mortem on locked doors.** Imagine it is a year later and it failed. List why. Then prevent the top three reasons.

WORKED EXAMPLE — Piotr, 39 · craft brewery in Kraków · 22 people

DECISION	Buy a €400,000 canning line or keep renting a mobile one.
BOX	■ SLOW DOWN Permanent and high stakes: seven years of debt.
PRE-MORTEM	Possible failures: the export deal falls through, rates rise, the line sits idle.
CHOICE	Rent for one more year, sign the export deal first, then buy.

AVOIDED
Debt based on a guess.

RULE SET
A pre-mortem for any purchase over €50,000.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which reversible decisions am I slowing down?

Which permanent decision am I rushing?

If this failed, what would the most likely reason be?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Haste and wisdom rarely travel together. Neither do fear and progress.

LEADERSHIP
Push reversible decisions down to your team. Keep the locked doors for yourself and your board.

BUSINESS
Speed on small decisions buys you time for the big ones.

PERSONAL
When a decision cannot be undone, sleep on it and ask someone who loves you and someone who does not.

> *"The thoughts of the diligent tend only to plenteousness; but of every one that is hasty only to want."*
> PROVERBS 21:5

PAIRS WITH THE P.A.C.E. DECISION LOOP (P. 10) · THE PROFIT LINE (P. 58) · 65

PHOTO 08
Portrait, at least 1,300 × 2,800 px
Natural light or black and white

ON THE MARKET

SERVE FIRST

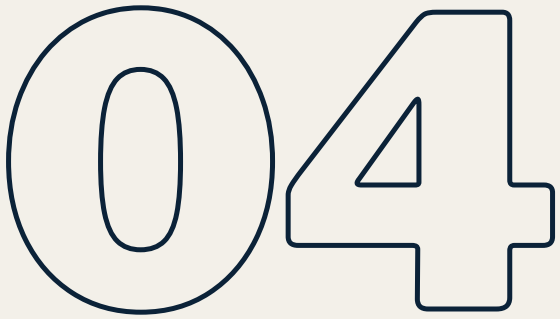
The market does not owe you attention. It gives it to people who are useful.

When I started sharing what I knew, I worried about giving too much away for free. The opposite happened: the people I helped first became the people who trusted me later.

This part is about your perfect client, the job they hire you for, your offer, trust, selling with care, standing apart and building momentum. Read it as a guide to serving better, and the selling will feel natural.

ONE THING TO DO THIS WEEK
Help one potential client this week without asking for anything in return.

Alexandru
ALEXANDRU COJOCARI · ROME





MARKET

LEAD IN THE MARKET

What does the world want and need from me?

Your client, their real job, your offer, trust, selling with care, standing apart and momentum.

25 The Perfect Client 68
26 The Job They Hire You For 70
27 The One-Line Offer 72
28 The Trust Ladder 74
29 The Humane Sale 78
30 Eliminate, Reduce, Raise, Create 80
31 The Flywheel 82
32 The Legacy Test 84

THE PERFECT CLIENT

> *When you try to serve everyone, you serve no one well. Define the client you serve best, and let the right ones find you.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL, FROM GET YOUR FIRST 100 PERFECT CLIENTS

WHO

Role, size, stage, place. Be specific.

PAIN

The problem that keeps them up at night



1 **Fill the four corners.**

2 **Write real clients** on the rings.

PLACE

Where they gather, read and ask for advice

PRICE

What they can pay, and pay gladly

☐ Rings: place real clients and leads ■ Gold centre: the client you serve best

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

One hour · repeat each year, or when you feel you are working for the wrong people

1. **Look at your best clients.** List the five you enjoyed most and earned most from. What do they share?
2. **Fill the four corners.** Who they are, the pain they feel, the places they gather and the price they pay gladly.
3. **Place real names on the rings.** Current clients and leads: perfect, good fit, or not for us.
4. **Say no to the outer ring.** Refer them to someone better suited. Your time is for the centre.
5. **Go where they are.** Spend the next 30 days in the places in your PLACE corner, helping first.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Rui, 36 · bookkeeping firm in Porto · 4 people
WHO	Owner-run restaurants with 10 to 40 staff in Porto and Braga.
PAIN	Late payroll and surprise tax bills in the busy season.
PLACE	The restaurant owners' association and two supplier newsletters.
PRICE	€450 a month, paid gladly to avoid fines.

SAID NO TO	IN 12 MONTHS
Start-ups wanting free advice.	From 30 to 74 clients.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Who are my three favourite clients, and why?

Which clients drain me and pay me least?

Could a stranger recognise my perfect client from my website?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Choosing someone means not choosing everyone. That is the price of being remembered.

LEADERSHIP
Tell your team who the perfect client is, so they can say no without asking you.

BUSINESS
A niche feels small until you see that it pays more and refers more.

PERSONAL
You are allowed to choose whom you serve.

> *"Everywhere means nowhere."*
> SENECA, LETTERS TO LUCILIUS

PAIRS WITH THE JOB THEY HIRE YOU FOR (P. 70) · THE TRUST LADDER (P. 74)

THE JOB THEY HIRE YOU FOR

> *People do not buy products. They hire them to make progress in their lives and work. Understand the job, and you understand the sale.*

BUILDS ON CLAYTON M. CHRISTENSEN'S JOBS TO BE DONE THEORY (HARVARD BUSINESS REVIEW, 2016)

1 Use the client's own words.

2 Name what you really compete with.

When _____

THE SITUATION THEY ARE IN

I want to _____

THE PROGRESS THEY WANT

So I can _____

THE DEEPER RESULT

FUNCTIONAL	EMOTIONAL	SOCIAL	COMPETITION
The practical task to get done	How they want to feel, or stop feeling	How they want to be seen by others	What else they could hire, including nothing

☐ Lines: the job, in your client's words ■ Gold line: the progress they want

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

Five interviews of 20 minutes · then one hour to write · repeat yearly

1. **Interview five recent buyers.** Ask what was happening in their life or business on the day they decided to buy.
2. **Write the job sentence.** When [situation], I want to [progress], so I can [deeper result]. Use their words.
3. **Fill the three layers.** Functional, emotional and social. The emotional one usually decides the sale.
4. **Name the real competition.** What else could do this job? Often a spreadsheet, a cousin or doing nothing.
5. **Rewrite your offer.** Speak to the job, not the features. Change one page, one email and one call script.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Elif, 32 · project management software in Berlin · 15 people
THE JOB	When my team grows past ten, I want to see who is doing what, so I can stop chasing people.
EMOTIONAL	To stop feeling out of control and embarrassed in client meetings.
COMPETITION	A shared spreadsheet and Monday-morning calls.
THE CHANGE	Her homepage now says: Stop chasing your team.

TRIAL TO PAID
From 4% to 9%.

LESSON
Features were never the reason.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

What progress are my clients really trying to make?

What do I compete with that is not a competitor?

Which emotional job do I ignore in my marketing?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Every purchase is a small hope for a better day. Respect it.

LEADERSHIP
Teach your team the client's job. Everyone, from support to finance, can serve it.

BUSINESS
Clients rarely switch for features. They switch when their situation changes.

PERSONAL
Ask more questions than you answer. Curiosity sells better than charm.

> *"Look not every man on his own things, but every man also on the things of others."*
> PHILIPPIANS 2:4

THE ONE-LINE OFFER

> *If your offer needs a paragraph, it is not ready. One line a client can repeat to a friend is worth more than a beautiful website.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL

1 Specific beats clever.

2 Test it on a stranger.

I help _____

WHO, SPECIFICALLY

get _____

THE RESULT, MEASURABLE

in _____

HOW LONG

without _____

THE PAIN OR RISK THEY FEAR

PROOF	PRICE	REPEAT TEST
One number or client story that makes it believable	What it costs, and what it saves them	Who repeated it back correctly?

☐ Lines: one specific answer each ■ Gold line: the result they want

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

30 minutes to draft · a week of saying it out loud to test it

1. **Name the who.** One type of client, not everyone: owners of small dental clinics.
2. **Name the result.** Something they can measure or see: ten new patients a month.
3. **Add time and risk.** How soon, and what they will not have to suffer: in 90 days, without discounting.
4. **Back it with proof.** One real number or client story. No proof yet? Offer a guarantee or a pilot.
5. **Run the repeat test.** Say it to five people. If three can repeat it a day later, keep it.

WORKED EXAMPLE — Tom, 34 · LinkedIn coach for accountants in Manchester · solo

BEFORE	I offer personal branding and content strategy services.
AFTER	I help accountants win three new clients a month from LinkedIn in 90 days, without cold calling.
PROOF	17 accountants, averaging 3.4 new clients a month.
RESULT	Discovery calls went from 2 to 9 a week.

REPEAT TEST
Four out of five got it.

PRICE
€1,500 for 90 days.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Can I say what I sell in one breath?

Would my best client describe it the same way?

Which word in my offer is vague?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Simplicity is not less. It is everything unnecessary taken away.

LEADERSHIP
If your team describes the offer five ways, the market hears five companies.

BUSINESS
Confused buyers do not buy. Clarity is the cheapest marketing you will ever do.

PERSONAL
Saying exactly whom you serve takes courage, and courage converts.

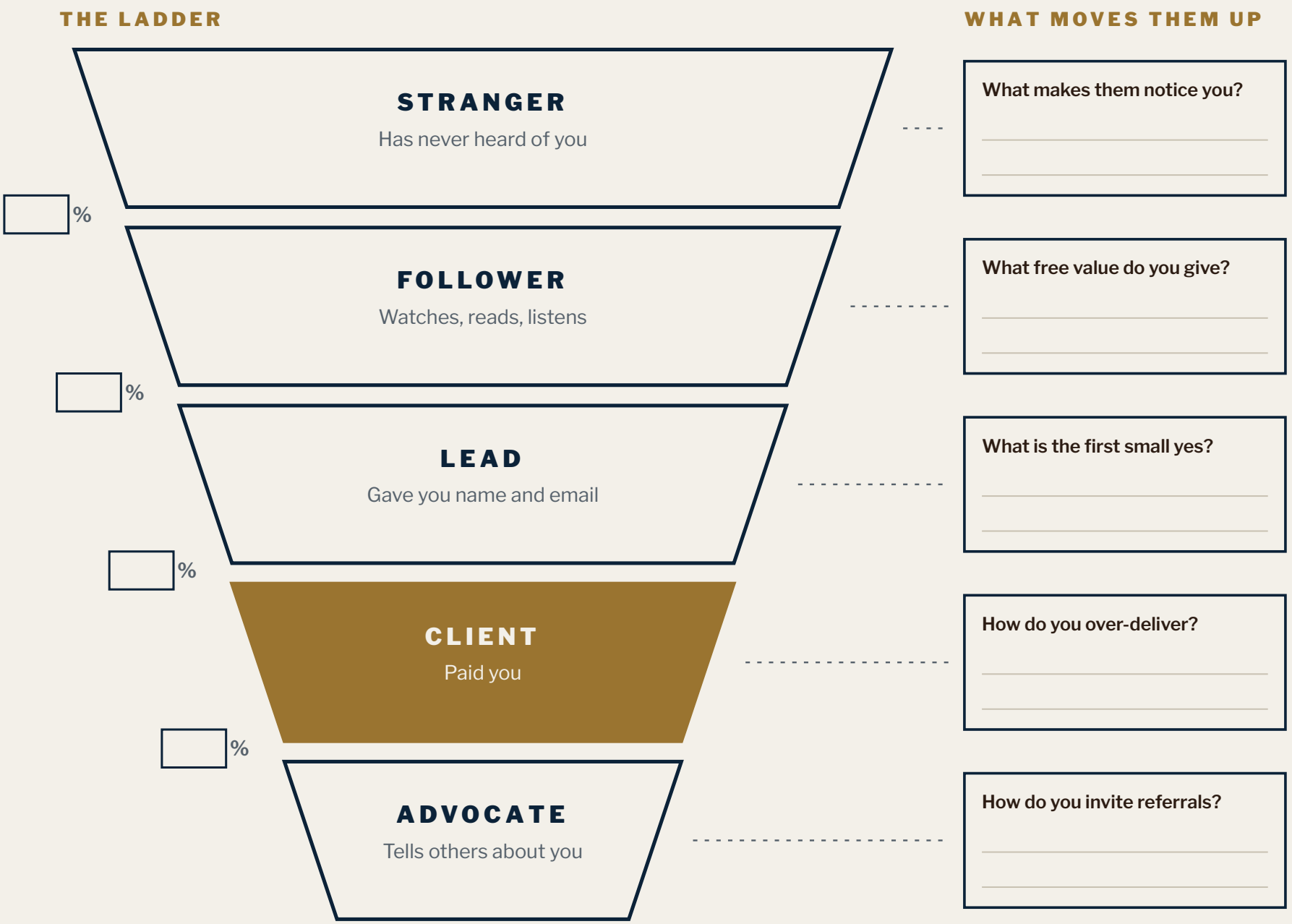
> *"A word fitly spoken is like apples of gold in pictures of silver."*
> **PROVERBS 25:11**

PAIRS WITH THE FOUR P'S (P. 48) · POINT, PROOF, PATH (P. 34) · 73

THE TRUST LADDER

> *Nobody goes from stranger to client in one step. Give people a reason to climb one rung at a time, and serve them on every rung.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL



1 Write the % that climbs to the next rung.

Small boxes: the % that climbs each rung Gold rung: where trust becomes revenue

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

One hour with this month's numbers · repeat monthly

1. **Map your ladder.** Write how people meet you, follow you, become leads, buy and refer. Use your real channels.
2. **Count each rung.** How many people are on each rung this month? Write the climb rate between rungs.
3. **Find the broken rung.** The lowest climb rate is where trust breaks. Fix that rung before you add more strangers.
4. **Give a reason to climb.** A useful free resource, a small first offer, a great first week, an invitation to refer.
5. **Serve every rung.** Help followers who may never buy. They are your reputation.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Daria, 31 · interior designer in Ljubljana · solo
FOLLOWERS	2,400 on Instagram and 10 enquiries a month.
BROKEN RUNG	■ LEAD TO CLIENT — Only one in ten enquiries booked.
THE FIX	A paid €150 design consultation, credited if they hire her.
RESULT	Four in ten now book, and two referrals a month.

FREE VALUE	ADVOCATES
A weekly room makeover video.	A thank-you gift after every project.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Where do people stop climbing in my business?

What small first yes could I offer?

How do I thank and reward the people who refer me?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Trust cannot be rushed. It can only be earned faster by serving better.

LEADERSHIP
Everyone in your company touches a rung. Show them which one.

BUSINESS
Doubling traffic to a broken ladder doubles your costs, not your clients.

PERSONAL
Give before you ask. Generosity is the most patient form of marketing.

> *"Withhold not good from them to whom it is due, when it is in the power of thine hand to do it."*
> PROVERBS 3:27

PAIRS WITH THE PERFECT CLIENT (P. 68) · THE HUMANE SALE (P. 78) · 75

PHOTO 09
Portrait, at least 1,300 × 2,800 px
Natural light or black and white

ON CHARACTER

BUILD A GOOD PEOPLE COMPANY

I would rather build a smaller company of good people than a large one I am ashamed of. Skills can be trained. Character is much harder to change.

A good people company keeps its promises when nobody is checking, pays fairly, tells clients the truth and helps its people grow. In the long run it is also the most profitable kind: clients stay, people stay, and reputation does the selling.

Profit and people are not enemies. Balance them, and you build something worth handing on.

ONE THING TO DO THIS WEEK
Write the three behaviours your company will never compromise on.

Alexandru
ALEXANDRU COJOCARI · ROME

CHECKPOINT

Pause before you go on. Four frameworks in, which one will change your next 30 days?

FRAMEWORK	USED IT	HOW MUCH IT FITS NOW, 1-5	ONE ACTION AND A DATE
The Perfect Client Page 68	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
The Job They Hire You For Page 70	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
The One-Line Offer Page 72	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	
The Trust Ladder Page 74	☐	☐☐☐☐☐	

THE ONE FRAMEWORK I WILL USE THIS MONTH, AND WHY

PAUSE	ASSESS	CHOOSE	EXECUTE
What is really happening?	Facts, options, costs	One option, and why	First step and date

FIELD NOTES

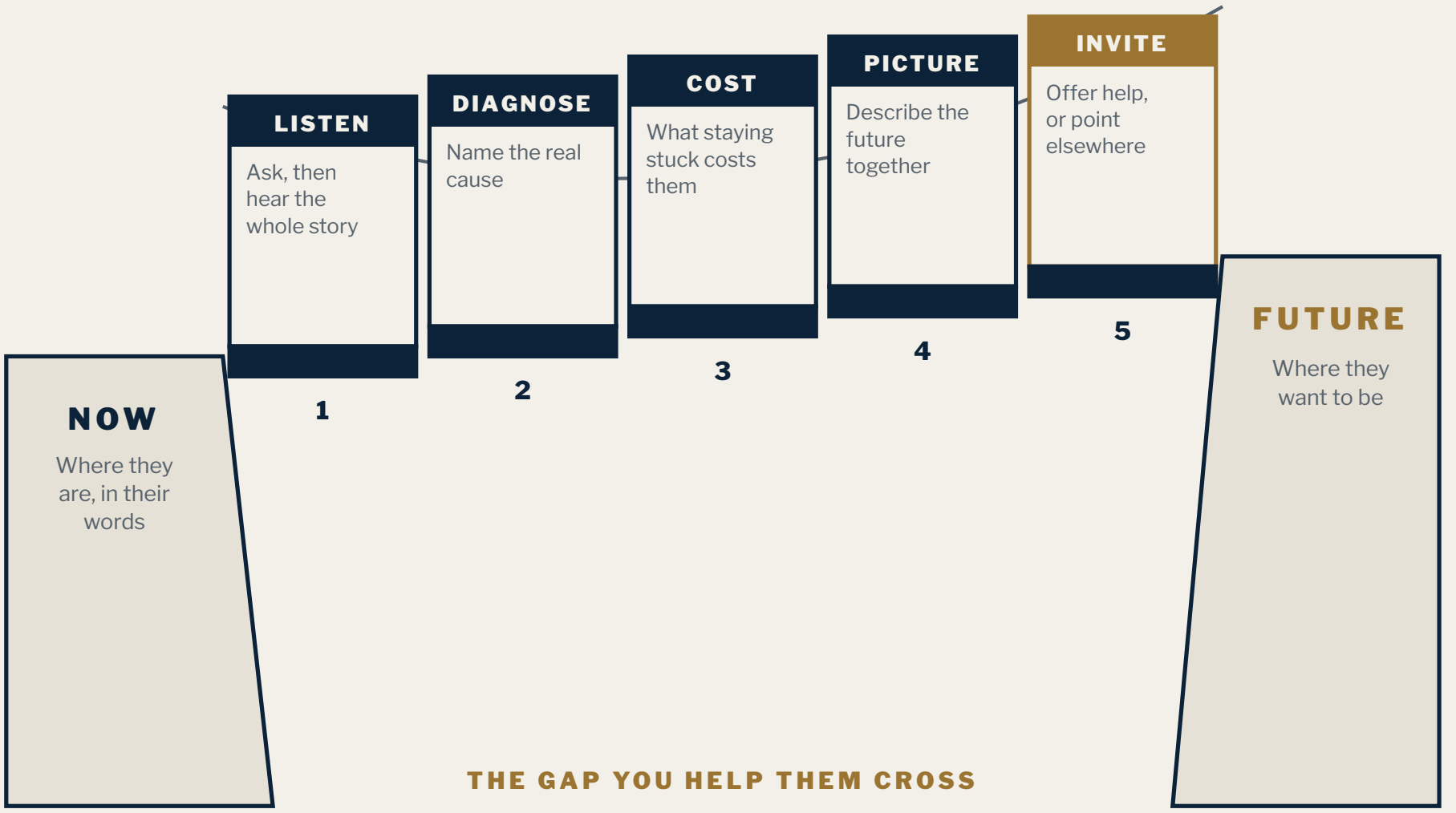
THE HUMANE SALE

> *Selling is helping someone cross from where they are to where they want to be. Teach with wisdom, sell with care, and never push anyone onto a bridge they do not need.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL: TEACH WITH WISDOM, SELL WITH CARE

1 Talk 30%, listen 70%.

2 Invite, never push.



Planks: the five steps of the conversation Gold plank: the invitation

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

Prepare 10 minutes before each sales call · review 5 minutes after it

1. **Listen first.** Ask about their situation, goals and what they have tried. Take notes and talk less than a third of the time.
2. **Diagnose honestly.** Name the real cause, even if it means your offer is not the answer.
3. **Price the gap.** Ask what staying stuck costs them in money, time, health or peace. Let them say the number.
4. **Picture the future together.** Describe what changes in 90 days if it works. Use their words, not your brochure.
5. **Invite with care.** Make one clear offer with the price. If it is not right for them, recommend someone who is.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Bianca, 40 · leadership coach for clinic owners in Rome · solo
NOW	A clinic owner working 70 hours a week; two managers about to quit.
COST	He estimated €80,000 a year in turnover and lost patients.
FUTURE	A 50-hour week and managers who stay.
INVITE	A six-month programme at €6,000, or a book if he was not ready yet.

RESULT	HER RULE
He joined; turnover halved.	Never sell to someone she cannot help.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Do my sales calls feel like help or like pressure?

When did I last tell someone my offer was not right for them?

What does the gap cost my clients?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Selling with care is service. Selling without care is taking.

LEADERSHIP
Train your sales team to diagnose, not to pitch. Trust grows, and so do sales.

BUSINESS
The best sales script is a good question followed by silence.

PERSONAL
You are not begging for money. You are offering help. Stand tall.

> *"All things whatsoever ye would that men should do to you, do ye even so to them."*
> MATTHEW 7:12

PAIRS WITH THE TRUST EQUATION (P. 28) · POINT, PROOF, PATH (P. 34) · 79

ELIMINATE, REDUCE, RAISE, CREATE

> *Do not fight for crumbs in a crowded market. Change the game: drop what clients do not value, add what nobody offers, and stand alone.*

BUILDS ON THE FOUR ACTIONS FRAMEWORK OF W. CHAN KIM AND RENÉE MAUBORGNE, BLUE OCEAN STRATEGY (2005)

ELIMINATE −−

What does your industry take for granted that clients do not value?

REDUCE −

What could be well below the industry standard?

RAISE +

What should be well above the industry standard?

CREATE ++

What has your industry never offered?

COMPARE YOURSELF WITH THE WHOLE INDUSTRY, NOT WITH ONE COMPETITOR

☐ Lines: what you will change in each box ■ Gold box: what makes you stand alone

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

90 minutes with your team · repeat once a year or when prices start falling

1. **List the industry's factors.** Everything firms in your market compete on: price, speed, features, location, service.
2. **Eliminate.** Which factors do clients not care about? Stop paying for them.
3. **Reduce.** Which ones are over-delivered? Bring them well below the standard.
4. **Raise and create.** Raise what clients wish they had. Create one thing nobody offers yet.
5. **Describe your new offer.** Write it in one line. If it sounds like everyone else, go back to step four.

WORKED EXAMPLE	Inés, 37 · dental clinic for anxious patients in Valencia · 9 people
ELIMINATE	The crowded waiting room and paper forms.
REDUCE	The treatment menu: fewer, simpler packages.
RAISE	Time with the dentist: every visit starts with ten calm minutes.
CREATE	A calm-visit programme and a nurse who answers the phone every evening.

PRICE	WAITING LIST
20% above the city average.	Six weeks.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

What does my industry do that clients only tolerate?

What could I stop doing tomorrow that nobody would miss?

What would make a client say: nobody else does that?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Competing on the same terms makes you a copy. Different is better than better.

LEADERSHIP
Ask your newest employee what seems strange in your industry. Fresh eyes see open water.

BUSINESS
You can cut costs and add value at the same time when you stop doing what clients never wanted.

PERSONAL
You do not have to win their game. You can choose your own.

> *"If you know the enemy and know yourself, you need not fear the result of a hundred battles."*
> SUN TZU, THE ART OF WAR

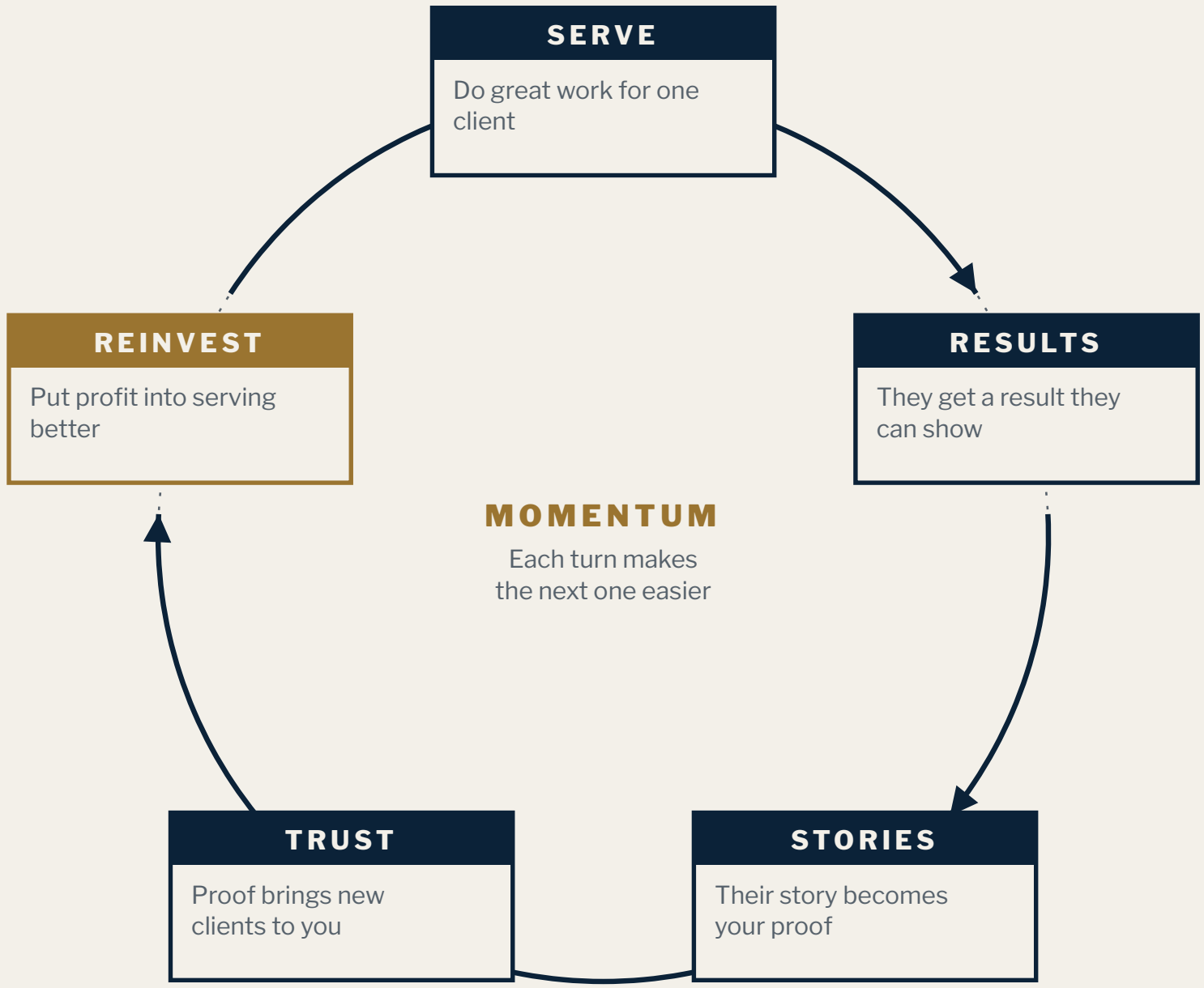
THE FLYWHEEL

> *Great businesses are not built by one big push but by many turns in the same direction. Design the loop in which each step feeds the next.*

BUILDS ON JIM COLLINS'S FLYWHEEL, GOOD TO GREAT (2001) AND TURNING THE FLYWHEEL (2019)

1 **Write your own steps** in the boxes.

2 **Mark the step that** slows the wheel.



☐ Boxes: write your own loop ■ Gold step: where profit feeds the wheel

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

One hour to design · one action per step every week

1. **Write your loop.** Four to six steps in which each one causes the next. Start from what you already do well.
2. **Check every arrow.** Does step A really cause step B? If not, the wheel is a wish.
3. **Find the slowest step.** Where does momentum leak? That step gets your attention this quarter.
4. **Turn it every week.** One concrete action per step, every week. Consistency beats intensity.
5. **Protect the direction.** Say no to projects that do not turn this wheel, however exciting they are.

WORKED EXAMPLE — Paul, 44 · personal training studio in Edinburgh · 6 trainers

LOOP	Coach well, visible results, client stories, referrals, more trainers.
SLOW STEP	■ STORIES — Great results, but nobody recorded them.
THE FIX	A monthly client spotlight with photos and numbers.
ONE YEAR ON	Referrals up from 3 to 11 a month.

SAID NO TO
Opening a supplement shop.

NEXT
Train a head coach.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

What loop makes my business stronger every month?

Which step do I keep skipping?

Which shiny project would stop the wheel?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
What you repeat, you become. What a business repeats, it becomes known for.

LEADERSHIP
Show your team the wheel. Everyone should know which step they push.

BUSINESS
Marketing tricks give you spikes. Flywheels give you compounding.

PERSONAL
Small, boring and repeated beats big, exciting and occasional.

> *"Wealth gotten by vanity shall be diminished: but he that gathereth by labour shall increase."*
> **PROVERBS 13:11**

PAIRS WITH THE TRUST LADDER (P. 74) · ONE OBJECTIVE, THREE RESULTS (P. 62) · 83

THE LEGACY TEST

> *A good company makes a profit, grows its people and serves a purpose bigger than itself. Lose one and you lose the right to last.*

EXPLORASELF ORIGINAL: THE BALANCE OF PROFIT AND PEOPLE



Dotted lines: a scale from 1 to 5 from each corner

Gold square: perfect balance

Worked example opposite →

FIVE MOVES

45 minutes once a year · ideally with your partner or board

1. **Score the three corners.** Profit, people and purpose, from 1 to 5, with one fact behind each score.
2. **Place your dot.** Inside the triangle, closer to your strongest corner. Be honest about the lean.
3. **Draw the arrow.** Where should the dot be in three years? Draw an arrow and write why.
4. **Choose one move per corner.** One action to protect profit, one to grow people, one to serve the purpose.
5. **Ask the legacy question.** If you sold or closed the company tomorrow, what would people say it stood for?

WORKED EXAMPLE — Victor, 58 · family printing company in Sibiu · 35 people

PROFIT	4: strong margins from packaging contracts.
PEOPLE	2: no training budget, average age 54, no successors.
PURPOSE	3: proud of local work, but never said it out loud.
MOVES	An apprentice programme, a written mission, the same margins.

THREE YEARS ON
Two apprentices lead shifts.

SUCCESSION
His daughter joins as COO.

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Which corner do I sacrifice when things get hard?

Who will lead this company when I step back?

What will people say my business stood for?

YOUR QUICK NOTE

NOTES THAT NEVER GET OLD

PHILOSOPHY
Achievement is an act of kindness when it lifts others with you.

LEADERSHIP
Your legacy is not the company you build. It is the people who grew because of it.

BUSINESS
Profit is oxygen, not purpose. Nothing lives without it, but it is not why we live.

PERSONAL
Build something you would be proud to hand to your children.

> *"Well done, thou good and faithful servant: thou hast been faithful over a few things, I will make thee ruler over many things."*
> MATTHEW 25:21

PHOTO 10
Portrait, at least 1,300 × 2,800 px
Natural light or black and white

YOUR TURN

ALLOW YOURSELF TO RISE

I believe each of us has been given talents, and that we are meant to multiply them, not bury them. Your business is one of the ways you do that.

You now have 32 tools. You do not need all of them this year. You need the right one this week, used with a pen and a decision.

Come back to these pages every 90 days. Your answers will change, because you will. And if you want someone to walk part of the road with you, my door is open.

ONE THING TO DO THIS WEEK
Turn the page and sign your commitment.

Alexandru
ALEXANDRU COJOCARI · ROME

MY COMMITMENT

A decision written down is a promise to yourself. Sign it, date it, and read it again in 90 days.

MY TEN-YEAR SENTENCE
Who I will be and what I will have built

MY PRIORITY THIS YEAR
The gold square on my 1-year ring

THE THREE FRAMEWORKS I USE FIRST
With page numbers

WHAT I WILL STOP DOING
To make room for the priority

MY MINIMUMS
Family, health and rest I will protect

WHO WILL HOLD ME TO IT
A name, and when I will tell them

SIGNATURE **DATE** **READ AGAIN ON**

PHOTO 11
Portrait or working photo
At least 1,000 × 1,400 px

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

ALEXANDRU COJOCARI

Alexandru was born in Moldova in 1989 and lives in Rome. For a decade and a half he has worked with people and led them: building teams, developing leaders and helping each person grow into the best version of themselves.

Those years taught him one lesson again and again: a team is never stronger than the person leading it, and people follow character long before they follow plans. Today, through ExploraSelf, he helps founders and business owners lead themselves, their people and their business.

WORK WITH ALEXANDRU	
Assessments	Find your lid, your gaps and your next step at exploraself.com
Personal Leadership Lab	Lead yourself first: exploraself.com/lab
A free 1:1 session	Apply on the home page of exploraself.com
Unshakeable	The Personal Leadership Manual, on Amazon

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